



CITY: Pg 2

Man murders wife, stages suicide after taking cue from crime series



NATION: Pg 5

19 ministers inducted into K'taka Cabinet



FILM: Pg 12

Huma Qureshi defends Kiara Advani

BJP WINS ONE, CONCEDES TWO IN THREE ASSEMBLY BY-POLLS

By-polls: Prashant Kishor ends BJP's 30-year hold on Bankipur

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: Jan Suraj founder and poll strategist Prashant Kishor scripted history on Monday by securing his party's maiden electoral victory in the high-stakes Bankipur Assembly by-poll in Bihar, defeating BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha by 19,324 votes.

In two other assembly by-elections, the BJP retained the Manjalpur seat in Gujarat's Vadodara district, with its candidate, Satendrabhai Patel, defeating Congress nominee Bhikhabhai Rabari by over 30,000 votes. The Congress has kept the Datia seat in Madhya Pradesh, with the party candidate Ghanishyam Singh defeating his nearest rival Ashutosh Tiwari of the BJP by over 6,000 votes.

Voting for the by-elections to the three assembly constituencies was held on the 30th of last month.



Jan Suraj Party chief Prashant Kishor celebrates with supporters after taking the lead in the Bankipur Assembly by-election during the counting of votes, in Patna, on Monday

After months of relentless campaigning, door-to-door outreach and countless hours on the ground, the Jan Suraj

founder can relish his electoral victory. In the process, Kishore's win ended the BJP's uninterrupted 30-year-old

hold over one of its strongest bastions in Bihar. The by-poll in the BJP bastion, which the party had never lost since

CLOSER LOOK

» Kishor defeated BJP candidate Neeraj Kumar Sinha by 19,324 votes

» Jan Suraj ended BJP's uninterrupted 30-year hold over the Bankipur seat

» Kishor polled 64,151 votes; BJP's Sinha received 44,827

» BJP retained Gujarat's Manjalpur seat with Satendrabhai Patel winning by over 30,000 votes

» CONGRESS RETAINED MADHYA PRADESH'S DATIA SEAT WITH GHANISHYAM SINGH WINNING BY OVER 6,000 VOTES

for the fifth consecutive term in November last year and resigned in April this year following his election to the Rajya Sabha.

Kishor polled 64,151 votes against Sinha's 44,827, while RJD's Rekha Gupta finished a distant third with 14,273 votes. Having surged ahead in the early counting trends, Kishor steadily increased his lead, with his victory becoming virtually certain by the 15th round of counting out of a total of 32 rounds.

Kishor had hit the campaign trail nearly two months before the BJP and the RJD launched their full-fledged election efforts. During this period, Kishor held public meetings, conducted extensive door-to-door outreach and built a booth-level organisation across the constituency, giving his fledgling party a head start over its rivals. **Continued on P4**

COURT CITES LACK OF EVIDENCE

Court acquits ex-WFI chief Brij Bhushan in sexual harassment case; wrestlers to move higher court

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: In a setback to India's top wrestlers, a Delhi court on Monday acquitted former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief and former BJP MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh in the sexual harassment case filed by six women wrestlers.

Co-accused Vinod Tomar, former WFI assistant secretary, was also acquitted of all charges. Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Ashwini Panwar pronounced the verdict in in-camera proceedings at the Rouse Avenue Courts.

Reacting to the verdict, wrestlers Vinesh Phogat and Bajrang Punia expressed disappointment and said the complainants would



challenge the acquittal before a higher court.

In a joint statement, they said the women wrestlers had decided to appeal against the judgment and had instructed their lawyers to file the appeal at the earliest.

"We had to gather a lot of

FROM DAY ONE, THE ENTIRE STATE MACHINERY, THE GOVERNMENT, AND THIS SYSTEM HAVE BEEN WORKING TO PROTECT BRIJ BHUSHAN

wrestlers stood firm and kept fighting against Brij Bhushan in court. We are deeply saddened that the court did not find Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh guilty of the sexual violence allegations made by the women wrestlers."

The statement further alleged that the state machinery had worked to protect Singh since the allegations first surfaced.

"From day one, the entire state machinery, the government, and this system have been working to protect Brij Bhushan," it said.

The case was filed by six women wrestlers, including World Championships medalist Vinesh Phogat.

Counsel for Singh and Tomar, Rajiv Mohan, said the court acquitted the **Continued on P4**

Justice M S Liberhan, who headed Babri Masjid inquiry commission, passes away



CHANDIGARH: Justice Manmohan Singh Liberhan, who headed the commission that probed the circumstances leading to the demolition of the Babri

mosque at Ayodhya, died at the age of 87. Punjab and Haryana High Court Bar Association President Rohit Sud said Justice Liberhan passed away here on Sunday. His last rites will be performed on Monday.

Justice Liberhan began his legal practice at the Punjab and Haryana High Court in 1964. He was elected to the Punjab and Haryana Bar Council in August 1970 and served as its member until February 11, 1987. He also served as the Bar Council's secretary from January 1976 to June 1983.

He was elevated as a judge of the Punjab and Haryana High Court on February 11, 1987. He was appointed Chief Justice of the Madras High Court on July 7, 1997, and later became the Chief Justice of the Andhra Pradesh High Court on February 28, 1998.

On December 16, 1992, Justice Liberhan was appointed head of the one-man inquiry commission into the Babri Masjid demolition. **MPOST**

Section 498A of IPC will also apply to live-in partners: SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has ruled that Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code, which punishes cruelty by a husband or his relatives, will now also cover live-in partners, provided there was a clear intention to marry.

The ruling came on Monday from a bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N Kotiswar Singh, while hearing a case on whether a man in a live-in relationship could be prosecuted under this law.

The court said live-in relationships have become common today, especially in cities, and the law needs to keep up with how people are actually choosing to live. It clarified that the protection will apply only to relationships that are "in the nature of marriage" between two consenting adults and that this wider reading is meant strictly for Section 498A and will not change how any other law is read.

"Cruelty, any which way, does not check at the door, whether the house it enters is that of a married woman or not," the bench said, adding that once cruelty enters a relationship, its damage only grows. The judges said the word "husband" in the section should be read in a purposive way, keeping in mind the law's reformative and protective purpose. **Continued on P4**



Section 498A is a provision in the Indian Penal Code, 1860, that deals with cruelty against a married woman by her husband or his relatives

Oppn insists on Ram temple donation 'theft' debate, Shah statement on 'police excesses'

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Parliament remained deadlocked on Monday as the government and the opposition failed to reach common ground during separate meetings of the Business Advisory Committees (BAC) of the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha, with both sides holding firm to their positions.

According to sources, opposition parties demanded a discussion on the alleged theft of donation money at the Ram temple in Ayodhya and sought a statement from Union Home Minister Amit Shah on the alleged police action against students protesting on July 20. The continuing

The government, meanwhile, accused the opposition, particularly the Congress, of disrupting parliamentary proceedings and avoiding debates on key legislation

disagreement is expected to prolong the impasse in both Houses.

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BILL PROPOSES MAJOR TAX REFORMS TO ATTRACT FOREIGN CAPITAL

Govt moves to ease offshore fund norms

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman is expected to introduce the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in Parliament soon, proposing a major overhaul of the tax framework for offshore investment funds managed from India while extending incentives for foreign investors, electronics supply chains and the rough diamond trade.

The Bill, circulated among Members of Parliament ahead of its introduction in the Lok Sabha, seeks to replace the Taxation Laws (Amendment) Ordinance promulgated on June 5. While the Ordinance granted tax

KEY POINTS

» Bill replaces June 5 tax relief Ordinance

» Offshore fund eligibility norms proposed to be eased

» Global income tax exemption for eligible offshore funds

» 25-investor requirement proposed to be removed

» 10% single-investor cap proposed to go

» Rs 100-crore corpus requirement proposed to be scrapped

» IFSC and non-IFSC funds to get uniform treatment

exemption on interest income and capital gains earned by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) from investments in government securities, the proposed legislation introduces a wider set of tax measures aimed at attracting global capital and strengthening

India's position as a fund management hub.

A key proposal is the substantial relaxation of eligibility conditions for Eligible Investment Funds (EIFs) managed from India to claim tax exemption on their global income.

Under the proposed amendments, offshore funds will no longer have to meet conditions such as maintaining at least 25 investors, limiting a single investor's participation to 10 per cent, restricting investment in a single entity to 25 per cent of the corpus,



also raised concerns over the platform's content moderation practices and alleged algorithmic bias. They questioned why objectionable material, including pornographic content, remained available while what they described as "genuine" content was removed.

One member asked Meta officials, "When Facebook has not removed a lot of other objectionable content, who removed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's video from the platform?" The member also sought to know who bore the "ultimate responsibility" for the incident. **Continued on P4**

compliance with Indian laws despite earning significant revenue from the country. According to sources, MPs

Centre tells SC it is committed to dropping FIRs against students



Court allows states to withdraw cases, orders probe into July 20 protest

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Monday assured the Supreme Court that it remained "serious" about its commitment not to pursue criminal cases against students who participated in protests over the alleged NEET paper leak, leading the apex court to clarify that Delhi and other states were free to close or withdraw FIRs against student protesters in accordance with law. The court also made it clear that the exemption would not apply to those accused of grave and heinous offences, ordered a high-powered inquiry into allegations of police excesses during the July 20 march to Parliament, and, in a separate hearing, sought a detailed account of safeguards adopted to secure the NEET examination process.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing petitions related to the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) agitation over the alleged examination paper leak and the police action that followed the July 20 protest in Delhi.

At the outset, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta informed the court that there had been "some misapprehension" over implementing

KEY POINTS

» SC says Delhi, states may withdraw FIRs against eligible protesters

» Court limits "criminal antecedents" to grave and heinous offences

» Over 2,700 protesters found with serious criminal antecedents, Centre says

» Mehta cites misunderstanding over implementing government's commitment

» SC orders high-powered probe into July 20 protest violence

» Former Supreme Court judge to head inquiry committee

» CJJ says excessive police force and hardened criminals deserve equal scrutiny

» Court considers protocol regulating pellet gun use during protests

the government's assurance regarding cases filed against protesters.

"There was some misapprehension about what to do with the FIRs against the protesters. I have instructions to say that the government is serious on that commitment to students," Mehta submitted. **Continued on P4**

Several WhatsApp users say their accounts 'put under review'

NEW DELHI: Instant messaging app WhatsApp on Monday put multiple accounts, including those in India, "under review" for 24 hours and blocked all the app features, prompting several affected users to flag the issue through social media.

When contacted, a WhatsApp spokesperson said: "We are always working to stay ahead of those trying to abuse our service and ban accounts to help keep other users safe. Sometimes we get this wrong and if we do, we try to fix it as quickly as possible to get people back to chatting."

The disruption was highlighted around 8 pm IST when users started **Continued on P4**

Kerala rain toll rises to 15, seven missing

MPOST BUREAU

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala Chief Minister V D Satheesan on Monday said 15 people have died and seven remain missing in rain-related incidents across the state, while rescue and relief operations have been stepped up amid continuing heavy rainfall. He said the overall situation was under control, with only a few areas in Pathanamthitta continuing to face serious difficulties. **Continued on P4**

— SWORD USED IN KILLING, RS 12.75 LAKH CASH AND SCOOTER RECOVERED —

Man murders wife, stages suicide after taking cue from crime series

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Believing that lessons from a Hollywood crime series would help him outsmart investigators, a 53-year-old Delhi man allegedly murdered his wife over a property dispute and fled with lakhs of rupees in cash, only to be tracked down through technical surveillance, police said on Monday.

The accused, Kamal Singh, was arrested near Mathura Railway Station after a multi-state manhunt by the Shahdara district police. During interrogation, he told investigators that he had been influenced by “The Staircase” and believed that hiding the murder weapon and placing another instrument of crime at the scene would help him evade the police.

The murder came to light on the night of July 30 after the couple’s son returned home and found his mother, Komal Singh



(50), lying in a pool of blood in their Gagan Vihar residence in Delhi’s Shahdara.

“The woman was found lying in a pool of blood with a blood-stained pair of scissors placed in her hand to make it appear that she had stabbed herself. However, the victim’s son suspected that his father had murdered his mother,” a senior police officer said.

During the investigation, police discovered that the accused had also purchased a sword, which was later recov-

CLOSER LOOK

» “Woman was found lying in a pool of blood with a blood-stained pair of scissors placed in her hand to make it appear that she had stabbed herself. Victim’s son suspected that his father had murdered his mother”

» During investigation, police discovered that the accused had also purchased a sword, which was later recovered and found to be the actual murder weapon. He had concealed it in his bag and attempted to dispose of it to destroy evidence, the officer stated

ered and found to be the actual murder weapon. He had concealed it in his bag and attempted to dispose of it to destroy evidence.

Police said, however, that CCTV footage became the biggest clue in unravelling the case. The footage established that after the couple’s two children left the house in the morning, only the accused and the victim remained inside.

Police also found footage allegedly capturing the victim’s screams, followed

by the accused leaving the house after concealing the weapon, believed to be the sword, in a bag.

“Probe revealed that Singh had withdrawn around Rs 7 lakh from his bank accounts before going into hiding. Technical surveillance tracked his movement from Delhi towards Gorakhpur, where he allegedly planned to escape to Nepal before abruptly changing course and heading towards Mathura to throw investigators off the trail,”

the officer said.

He further said that he was intercepted near Mathura Railway Station, where police recovered a total of Rs 12.75 lakh in cash and a scooter allegedly used to flee after the murder.

During questioning, Singh admitted that he had planned the killing in advance because of a long-running dispute over family properties and had purchased the scissors a few days back before the planned murder.

“He also confessed that he intended to dispose of the weapon after watching ‘The Staircase’, believing it would frustrate the investigation. The team, however, said scientific investigation, CCTV analysis and technical surveillance dismantled the carefully planned escape strategy,” the officer said.

Further investigation, including forensic examination and additional recoveries, is underway.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A couple died after the roof of their single-storey rented house collapsed in northeast Delhi’s New Usmanpur area, police said on Monday. A child who was also inside the house escaped unhurt.

The incident took place around 10 pm on Sunday in JP Nagar, under the jurisdiction of New Usmanpur police station. According to police, the couple was inside the house when the roof suddenly gave way, trapping them under the debris.

Police, fire department personnel and rescue teams rushed to the spot after receiving information about the collapse and launched a rescue operation.

The couple was pulled out from the rubble and taken to a hospital, where doctors declared them dead.

The deceased were identified as Tinku, 32, and his wife, Urmila, 30, police said.

The bodies have been sent to Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital for post-mortem examination. Police said the



“The couple was pulled out from the rubble and taken to a hospital, where doctors declared them dead”

exact cause of the collapse is yet to be ascertained and an investigation is underway.

A case under Sections 290 (negligent conduct) and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) has been registered at New Usmanpur police station against the house owner, Virender Kumar.

Further investigation is in progress.

Couple dies after being hit by train

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 23-year-old man and a 20-year-old woman died after being hit by a train between Okhla and Hazrat Nizamuddin railway stations, with police suspecting suicide, an officer said on Monday.

Railway Police received information through a railway memo at 8.47 pm on Sunday and rushed to the spot. The bodies were found on the tracks and identified as Sagar, 23, and Shivani, 20, both residents of Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh.

The bodies were sent to LNJP Hospital for post-mortem and their families informed. Preliminary investigation suggests they jumped in front of a moving train, but the exact circumstances are being verified.

Delhi and Sonipat police step up security for Kanwar Yatra, I-Day

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police and Haryana’s Sonipat Police on Monday held an inter-state coordination meeting to strengthen security arrangements and ensure smooth conduct of the Kanwar Yatra and Independence Day celebrations.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outer North) Shobhit D Saxena chaired the meeting at the DCP Office Complex in Outer North district. Senior officers from both forces, including DCPs, Additional DCPs, senior divisional police officers and station house officers, attended.

The meeting focused on maintaining law and order, facilitating the safe movement of Kanwariyas through the area and strengthening security in view of Independence Day. Officers reviewed existing intelligence-sharing mechanisms and preventive policing

“Meet focused on maintaining law and order, facilitating the safe movement of Kanwariyas through the area and strengthening security...”

measures to respond swiftly to any potential incident.

Both forces agreed to share intelligence on anti-social elements, organised gangs, inter-state criminals, terrorism and anti-national activities, and to formulate joint preventive action plans. Contact details of duty officers and border beat staff will also be exchanged between adjoining police stations to facilitate round-the-clock coordination.

Joint inter-state checkpoints will be established to identify illegal activities, including

unauthorised vehicle modifications, tinted windscreens and defective number plates. Police will also maintain databases of High Security Registration Plate (HSRP) agencies and CCTV camera locations to strengthen surveillance and traffic management.

As part of preparations for the Kanwar Yatra, officers will monitor suspicious vehicles, Kanwar camps, liquor and meat shops along the route, as well as objectionable or inflammatory material displayed in public spaces. Such material will be removed promptly after proper documentation.

The forces also discussed coordination on cybercrime, traffic management, public gatherings, protests and other inter-state investigations. The meeting concluded with a commitment to timely intelligence-sharing and joint preventive action to ensure security during the upcoming events.

HC directs MCD & NDMC to start pilot project to sterilise stray dogs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Monday asked the civic authorities here to start a pilot programme for the sterilisation of stray dogs.

A bench of Justices Dinesh Mehta and Rajneesh Kumar Gupta asked the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) to organise a sterilisation camp in one ward each under their respective jurisdictions while duly publicising that the strays were not being captured or taken away.

The bench also orally observed that the authorities should make sure that at least five per cent of stray dog population is spared so that their numbers do not dwindle critically and the next generation can also see stray dogs.

“NDMC and MCD shall organise a camp in one ward each in their area for sterilisation of street/stray dogs in their



area with consultation with (the amicus curiae), which shall be taken as pilot project. Prior publicity of this camp in the area shall be given and a placard shall be displayed for wide publicity that stray dogs are not being captured for sending them to dog pounds, etc, and that they are being brought to the camp only for sterilisation/vaccination,” ordered the court.

The bench was hearing a suo motu case initiated by the high court pursuant to the directions of the Supreme Court.

During the hearing, the counsel for the MCD said that while there is no official data or census, the capital is roughly

estimated to have around eight lakh stray dogs.

On May 19, the Supreme Court directed the state governments and Union territories to augment infrastructure to deal with stray dogs and other animals, and asked all the high courts to register a suo motu case to ensure compliance of its August 22, 2025, and November 7, 2025, directions.

The top court issued a slew of directions to deal with the alarming rise in dog-bite incidents within institutional areas such as educational institutions, hospitals and railway stations.

While dealing with a suo motu case on the stray dog menace, the apex court ordered the relocation of stray canines to designated shelters after due sterilisation and vaccination.

It also directed the authorities to ensure the removal of all cattle and other stray animals from state highways, national highways and expressways.

DU opens preference window for mid-entry UG admissions

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The University of Delhi has opened the preference-edit window under Application Phase II of the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) for eligible undergraduate aspirants seeking admission through the Mid-Entry route.

Candidates can now log in to the DU CSAS portal, access Application Phase II and edit their existing preferences or add new programme and college choices.

The window will remain open until August 5 at 4:59 p.m. Candidates have been advised to save their preferences carefully, as the last

saved preference list will be considered for Mid-Entry seat allocation.

The Mid-Entry facility provides an additional opportunity to students who could not participate in the regular CSAS admission process. It may benefit candidates who did not register earlier, registered but failed to submit their preference list, or missed the regular admission window.

Mid-Entry does not guarantee admission, with allotment based on CUET scores, category, preferences and seat availability. Candidates have been advised to submit preferences before the deadline to avoid technical issues.

Gzb psychiatrist found dead after fall from 5th-floor apartment; cops probe all angles

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A 40-year-old psychiatrist was found dead after allegedly falling from the balcony of her fifth-floor apartment in Officers City 2 Society in Raj Nagar Extension on Monday. Police suspect suicide but said all angles are being investigated.

The deceased, identified as Dr Hemika Agrawal, ran a psychiatric clinic near the Ghaziabad bus stand. She was the daughter of senior psychiatrist Dr R Chandra, a resident of Raj Nagar.

The incident came to light after emergency helpline 112 received a call reporting that

“No suicide note was recovered from the flat. Forensic experts examined the scene and collected evidence for further analysis”

a woman had fallen from an upper floor of the residential complex. A police team reached the society and found Dr Agrawal lying on an internal road. She was declared dead at the spot.

Ziauddin Ahmad, ACP, Nandgram, said the preliminary investigation indicated that Dr Agrawal had been living alone in the apartment.

“She had divorced her husband around 18 months ago. Family members told

police that she had been under depression since then and had stopped attending her clinic for more than a month,” he said.

Police said no suicide note was recovered from the flat. Forensic experts examined the scene and collected evidence for further analysis.

A senior police officer said Dr Agrawal’s estranged husband, who is also a doctor based in Delhi, had been involved in legal disputes with

her following their separation. Police said Dr Agrawal had earlier filed a dowry harassment complaint against him at Kavi Nagar police station, while he had lodged an extortion complaint against her.

Police are recording statements from family members, neighbours and others associated with the case to reconstruct the circumstances leading to her death. The post-mortem examination has been conducted, and the exact cause of death will be established after the report is received.

No foul play has been established so far, police said, adding that the investigation is continuing.

City witnesses warmest August night-time temp in three years

NEW DELHI: Delhi witnessed the warmest August night-time temperatures in three years on Monday, with the minimum temperature at the city’s base station in Safdarjung settling at 28.4 deg Celsius, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The same station recorded the maximum temperature at 35.6 degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches above normal.

Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 34.4 degrees Celsius, 0.5 notches below normal, while Lodhi Road registered 34.8 degrees Celsius, 1.8 notches above the seasonal average.

Among the weather stations, the Ridge recorded a

maximum temperature of 33.7 degrees Celsius, 0.5 notches below normal, while Ayanagar logged 34 degrees Celsius, 0.4 notches below normal.

Light rainfall was reported in parts of the city during the day, with 13.3 mm recorded at Ayanagar between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, while the Ridge received trace rainfall. No rainfall was recorded during the period at Safdarjung, Palam and Lodhi Road.

Earlier, the minimum temperature at Safdarjung, the city’s primary weather station, was 28.4 degrees Celsius, Palam was 26.2 degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches above normal, while Lodhi Road recorded 27.8 degrees Celsius, 2 notches

above the season’s average.

Among other stations, Ridge recorded a minimum of 24.4 degrees Celsius, 2.1 notches above normal, while Ayanagar registered 27.5 degrees Celsius, 1.1 notches above normal. The city also recorded light rainfall activity over the past 24 hours, with trace rainfall at Safdarjung and Palam, 0.4 mm at Lodhi Road, 3.0 mm at Ridge and 6.8 mm at Ayanagar, recorded till 8.30 am.

Delhi’s 24-hour average air quality at 4 pm was recorded in the ‘satisfactory’ category with the average air quality index (AQI) being clocked at 76, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

NEW DELHI: The Delhi zoo is set to acquire 109 new wild-life species and 2,943 animals under its proposed modernisation plan, taking its collection to 201 species. The plan, backed by Rs 3.78 crore from the Centre, includes cheetahs, New World monkeys, mouse deer and butterflies.

Mouse deer will return to the National Zoological Park after nearly 30 years. The animals will primarily be acquired through exchange programmes with other zoos, officials said.

The expansion comes as the zoo’s collection has declined from 99 species three years ago to 92 species and 1,255 animals currently. The zoo has also lacked giraffes since 2014 and zebras since 2013,



“The zoo has also lacked giraffes since 2014 and zebras since 2013, while its last chimpanzee died in 2019”

while its last chimpanzee died in 2019. It currently has no

African elephant.

The proposed acquisitions follow several animal deaths in recent months, including a civet, chinkara, nilgai, jackal and endangered Sangai deer. The zoo also faced controversy after a jackal escaped its enclosure in December 2025 and was later declared dead from suffocation.

Earlier this year, a two-year-old white tigress, Durga, suffered a fracture while being prepared for transfer to Patna zoo.

The zoo said the expansion would strengthen conservation, breeding and educational programmes. It has also begun using artificial incubation and recently recorded its first rat snake hatch in seven years. PFI

Police unearth online child adoption fraud, apprehend 2 from UP

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted a cyber fraud racket that allegedly duped people on the pretext of arranging child adoptions and arrested two men from Uttar Pradesh’s Bareilly, an officer said on Monday.

The arrests were made after a complaint was lodged by a 30-year-old woman from Delhi’s Burari, who was allegedly cheated of Rs 1.37 lakh while trying to adopt a child, police said. According to the police, the woman had searched online for child adoption services and contacted a mobile number where the caller identified himself as Sachin and claimed to represent an organisation facilitating legal adoptions.

“The accused assured her that a baby boy would be available for adoption and collected money in phases, including registration, booking and transportation charges. To make the process appear genuine, he

even sent forged NGO receipts, fabricated ultrasound reports and other fake documents,” a senior police officer said. Police said the woman became suspicious after the accused repeatedly avoided her requests to meet the biological mother and later stopped responding to her calls after receiving the money.

“She then lodged a complaint through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, following which an e-FIR was registered at the cyber police station in north district,” the officer said.

Police tracked nearly 100 mobile numbers and analysed digital and financial trails before arresting two suspects in Bareilly. Police recovered forged medical documents, 14 hospital and doctor stamps, phones, SIM cards and bank documents, while probing other members and victims linked to the alleged adoption racket.

AIMS TO REDUCE TEXTILE WASTE

Delhi to set up ‘Arpan’ centres at Metro stns for old clothes, recycling

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: While advancing Delhi’s sustainability agenda, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday inaugurated ‘Arpan’, a donation centre for old clothes, at Punjabi Bagh West Metro Station.

The initiative seeks to transform discarded but wearable garments into a resource for reuse, recycling and upcycling, reducing textile waste while creating livelihood opportunities for women.

Launching the initiative, Gupta said the campaign reflects the government’s commitment to promoting sustainable waste management and encouraging responsible consumption among citizens.

“Arpan’ is not just a donation centre but a movement towards a cleaner, greener and more sustainable Delhi.

Through this initiative, wearable clothes that often lie unused in homes can be reused, recycled or upcycled, reducing textile waste while benefiting those in need. At the same time, it will generate sustainable livelihood opportunities for women engaged in the collection, sorting and processing of donated clothes,” she said.

The Chief Minister urged residents to actively participate in the campaign by donating clothes that are no longer in use but remain wearable.

“I appeal to every citizen of Delhi to become a partner in this initiative. A small contri-



“The donated garments will be channelled for reuse, recycling and upcycling, ensuring that clothing remains in circulation for as long as possible”

bution from every household can make a significant difference to environmental conservation and social welfare,” Gupta said.

According to the Delhi government, the initiative has been designed to strengthen the Capital’s circular economy by extending the life cycle of clothing and reducing the burden of textile waste on landfills. Reusing and recycling garments is expected to conserve resources, lower waste generation and promote environmentally responsible practices.

To make the initiative accessible to the public, the government will establish 10 ‘Arpan’ donation centres across Delhi Metro stations. The centres will serve as convenient col-

lection points where residents can deposit old but wearable clothes for further processing.

Officials said the donated garments will be channelled for reuse, recycling and upcycling, ensuring that clothing remains in circulation for as long as possible instead of being discarded.

The initiative is also expected to strengthen community participation in waste reduction efforts while creating employment opportunities for women involved in managing the donated material.

With the launch of ‘Arpan’, the Delhi government hopes to encourage citizens to embrace sustainable habits and contribute towards building a cleaner, greener and more environmentally conscious Capital.

Delhi plans subsidy to make rooftop solar cheaper

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is preparing to overhaul its Solar Policy with a proposal that could drastically reduce the upfront cost of installing rooftop solar panels for households. Instead of releasing generation-based incentives over five years, the government plans to provide the benefit at the time of installation, a move aimed at accelerating solar adoption across the national capital.

Power Minister Ashish Sood told *Millennium Post* that “the revised policy has been finalised by the department and will soon be placed before the Cabinet. The proposal seeks to address what the government considers the biggest obstacle preventing residents from switching to solar power, the high initial investment required to install rooftop systems.”

According to the minis-



“Subsidy package could cover nearly 90% of installation cost, leaving many households to contribute only a small portion”

ter, the revised framework will combine incentives available under the Centre and the Delhi government so that eligible households receive most of the financial support upfront. “The current subsidy model requires consumers to wait several years to receive the full benefit. We want to change that by extending the assistance at the beginning itself, bringing down the amount families need to invest,” Sood said.

He added that the subsidy package could cover nearly 90 per cent of the installation cost, leaving many households to

contribute only a small portion, depending on the size of the system. “For a large number of homes, a 2-kW rooftop system is adequate to meet electricity needs. Under the proposed model, the consumer’s financial contribution could come down to roughly Rs.15,000,” he said.

At present, residential consumers are eligible for financial assistance under both the Centre’s PM Surya Ghar-Muft Bijli Yojana and the Delhi Solar Policy. While the Central scheme provides subsidies of up to Rs.78,000, the existing Delhi policy offers an additional cap-

Five rescued after fire breaks out in hotel’s kitchen

NEW DELHI: At least five people were rescued after a fire broke out in the kitchen of a hotel in Rohini’s Sector 7 on Monday afternoon, Delhi Fire Service officials said.

The DFS received a call about the blaze at 2.12 pm and rushed four fire tenders to the spot. The fire broke out on the second floor. Roop Narain (32), Anil (25), Gautam (25), Sarabjeet (38) and an unidentified person were rescued. No injuries were reported. The fire was brought under control by 2.50 pm. The cause remains unknown. Forensic teams reached the spot and further investigation is underway. *MP05T*

SKA to protest at Jantar Mantar over sewer deaths, alleges underreporting of fatalities

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Safai Karmachari Andolan (SKA) will stage a protest at Jantar Mantar on Tuesday, August 4, at 3 pm, demanding accountability over deaths caused during sewer and septic tank cleaning and alleging that the government has significantly underreported such fatalities.

The demonstration, organised under the banner #STOP-KILLINGUS, aims to draw attention to what the organisation describes as continued official apathy towards manual scavenging-related deaths and alleged attempts to suppress the actual figures.

Organisation has also reiterated its demand for complete mechanisation of sewer and septic tank cleaning ops

According to SKA, at least 593 people have died while cleaning sewers and septic tanks between January 2021 and August 2026. However, the organisation claims that “the Central government has acknowledged only 332 deaths in Parliament during the same period, leaving hundreds of cases unaccounted for.”

The organisation said the protest seeks to highlight the gap between official records and data compiled through

independent documentation. It alleged that the underreporting of fatalities has resulted in affected families being denied justice, compensation and rehabilitation.

SKA has urged the government to ensure transparency in recording all sewer and septic tank deaths, hold authorities accountable for violations of safety norms, and strictly enforce the legal prohibition on hazardous manual cleaning of sewers. The organisation

has also reiterated its demand for complete mechanisation of sewer and septic tank cleaning operations to eliminate the need for workers to enter toxic confined spaces.

The protest is expected to bring together sanitation workers, activists, civil society organisations and families of victims from different parts of the country. Participants will call for stronger implementation of existing laws protecting sanitation workers and for immediate measures to prevent further loss of life.

SKA urged media coverage of the protest, saying it aims to highlight systemic failures and amplify families’ voices.

41% turnout in MCD elections for Town Vending Committees

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Polling for the constitution of 23 Town Vending Committees (TVCs) across all 12 zones of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) concluded peacefully, with approximately 41 per cent of the nearly 90,000 registered voters exercising their franchise, according to the civic body.

Polling began at 8 a.m. at designated polling stations across the zones. The elections were conducted under the Street Vendors (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014 and the Delhi Street Vendors Rules, 2017.

The polling process was conducted under the supervision of MCD Chief Election Officer and Additional Commissioner Sanjeev Mittal, along with officials from the Central Licensing Department, zonal administrations

and Returning Officers.

The civic body said adequate security, voter facilitation and law-and-order arrangements were put in place at the polling stations. Zonal control rooms monitored polling and voter turnout on an hourly basis to ensure the smooth conduct of the process.

Counting on August 4

The MCD has established 15 strong rooms and 17 counting centres for the election. Counting of votes will begin at 8 am on August 4 at the notified counting centres.

The Corporation said no untoward incident or law-and-order issue was reported from any polling station during the day. The MCD thanked officials and agencies for conducting the polls, saying the exercise would strengthen street vendors’ representation and participatory civic governance.

Yamuna flood wall likely by March 2027, Delhi tells NGT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government’s Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) Department has informed the National Green Tribunal (NGT) that a proposed flood protection wall along a vulnerable stretch of the Yamuna is expected to be completed by March 31, 2027, as part of efforts to strengthen the Capital’s flood management system after the devastating inundation witnessed in 2023.

According to an official, the department submitted a status report before the tribunal on Saturday, outlining the feasibility of constructing the protective wall between the Magazine Drain and the Old Railway Bridge. While the preliminary feasibility study has been completed, the project is currently in the design and drawing stage. The report noted that execution will begin after obtaining mandatory approvals from statu-

Report noted that execution will begin after obtaining mandatory approvals from statutory agencies

tory agencies, including the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG).

The department said the embankment along the proposed stretch had been overtopped during the July 2023 floods, when the Yamuna touched a record water level of 208.66 metres at the Delhi Railway Bridge, exceeding the existing bund height and resulting in widespread flooding. It recommended structural interventions to prevent a recurrence of such incidents.

The report also made it clear that the long-pending proposal to transfer control of the ITO barrage to the

Delhi government is unlikely to move forward. Haryana’s Irrigation Department has informed Delhi that the barrage needs to remain under its control as it plays a crucial role in measuring water discharge shared among Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan. Referring to the recommendations of the Joint Flood Management Committee constituted after the 2023 floods, the report said the panel had advised operating the ITO barrage with all gates open during flood situations in coordination with the Wazirabad and Okhla barrages. It also stressed the need for regular maintenance of the barrage’s hydro mechanical systems while suggesting that the issue of transferring the barrage may be considered separately by the appropriate authorities.

I&FC ruled out floodwater diversion reservoirs in Delhi, citing land constraints, silt deposition and high costs.

Kejriwal to march to PM residence over E20 Fuel

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) National Convener Arvind Kejriwal on Monday announced that he would lead a march to the Prime Minister’s residence on Tuesday to submit a public petition opposing the “forceful imposition” of E20-blended petrol.

Kejriwal said he would leave the AAP headquarters at noon with 100 people to personally hand over a petition signed by 2,33,238 people and seek a meeting with the Prime Minister over concerns surrounding ethanol-blended fuel.

Addressing a press conference, Kejriwal said people across the country were “deeply troubled” by E20-blended petrol, alleging that vehicle mileage was declining and vehicles were being damaged.

He questioned the government’s continued push for ethanol-blended fuel, saying it had provided neither answers nor justification for the policy and alleg-

ing that this raised suspicions of a “hidden agenda”.

Kejriwal also referred to an allegation that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had come under pressure from US President Donald Trump to import ethanol from the United States. He claimed that, according to one estimate, Modi would purchase \$20 billion worth of ethanol from Trump over the next five years, with the fuel then being imposed on consumers in India.

Referring to the AAP’s recent campaign, Kejriwal said the ‘National Town Hall Against E20’, held on Saturday, was an “overwhelming success”, with the venue packed, large crowds gathered outside and nearly 700,000 people watching the event live online. He said the response demonstrated the level of public support for the campaign.

Kejriwal alleged E20 critics faced trolling and FIR threats; AAP’s petition garnered 2,33,238 signatures, while his request for a PM meeting remained unanswered.

MCD’s Hindu Rao Hospital unveils upgraded facilities

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi’s (MCD) Hindu Rao Hospital on Monday inaugurated a range of upgraded medical facilities and advanced equipment, aimed at strengthening emergency care, diagnostics and specialised treatment.

Delhi Mayor Praveesh Wahi inaugurated the facilities at a ceremony attended by Deputy Mayor Monica Pant, Standing Committee chairperson Satya Sharma, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar, senior officials, doctors and public representatives.

The upgrades include a renovated Casualty Department, Dharamshala and Physiotherapy Block, an integrated blood sample collection centre and advanced ophthalmology equipment.

A 4K laparoscopy system, C-Arm machine and other medical infrastructure were also inaugurated, with some facilities launched through e-inauguration.

Among the newly commissioned equipment are Optical Coherence Tomography, Visual Field Analyser, Fundus Camera, Phacoemulsification Machine, Non-Contact Tonometer, Cryoablator, Advanced 4K Laparoscope and Pneumatic Lithotripter. A modern labour room, paediatric spirometer, cardiocardiography (CTG) equipment and a gym in the Physiotherapy Department were also inaugurated.

The ceremony also marked 25 years of the hospital’s Diplomat of National Board (DNB) programme, which began in 2001 with 21 seats across eight specialities. It now has 51 accredited seats across 10 specialities, with 71 faculty members involved in medical education and training.

Wahi said the upgraded facilities would strengthen the capacity of MCD hospitals to provide quality treatment free of cost. He urged doctors and staff to ensure that patients receive compassionate and respectful care.

The hospital administration said the new infrastructure would improve access to specialised treatment and strengthen Hindu Rao Hospital’s role in healthcare and medical education.

Delhi govt reviews ₹193-crore Ghazipur poultry market proj

NEW DELHI: In a push to modernise Delhi’s agricultural trading infrastructure, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday reviewed the progress of key redevelopment projects across the capital’s wholesale markets, including the nearly completed Rs.193-crore modern poultry market at Ghazipur, a proposed flower market at the Integrated Freight Complex (IFC), and new infrastructure at the Narela Grain Market.

Chairing a high-level review meeting, the Chief Minister assessed the status of ongoing and proposed projects in Ghazipur, Narela and IFC Ghazipur, while also examining measures to strengthen basic infrastructure in the city’s agricultural mandis. Emphasising the importance of agricultural markets in Delhi’s economy, Gupta said, “Delhi’s agricultural markets serve as a crucial link between farmers, traders and consumers, and developing them in line with present-day requirements is a priority for the government.”

She added, “Well-planned markets equipped with modern facilities and stronger infra-



structure will not only make trade more efficient but also strengthen the entire agricultural marketing system. The government is regularly reviewing all projects to ensure development works progress according to the stipulated timelines.”

Officials informed the Chief Minister that the modern poultry market being developed over nearly 15 acres in Ghazipur has reached around 85 per cent completion. The project, estimated at Rs.193.29 crore, began construction in March 2019 and is scheduled to be completed by December 31, 2026. Once operational, the facility will accommodate 100 wholesale traders and include 120 processing units, significantly upgrading poultry trade infrastructure in the capital.

The meeting also reviewed ongoing works at the Ghazipur Fruit, Vegetable and Flower Market. Officials said a 200-metre bypass drainage pipeline, costing around Rs.17 lakh, is being laid to address persistent waterlogging in the market. They added that regular drives are being carried out to remove stray animals and improve sanitation within the mandi premises. Another major proposal discussed was the construction of two additional steel sheds at the Narela Grain Market to meet the growing requirements of traders. The project, estimated to cost around Rs.11 crore, is expected to be completed by July 2027.

The review also covered plans for a modern flower market at the Integrated Freight Complex (IFC), Ghazipur, where around 10 acres of land acquired from the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) in 2001 will be developed in phases.

Gupta said the government would strengthen agricultural market infrastructure and ensure timely project completion, benefiting farmers, traders and consumers alike. *MP05T*

CITY-WIDE AUDIT OF BRIDGES AND FLYOVERS UNDERWAY

Capital begins work on ₹2-crore footbridge over Najafgarh Drain

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi’s Public Works Department (PWD) has begun construction of a new pedestrian bridge over the Najafgarh Drain in North Delhi, aiming to end years of inconvenience faced by thousands of residents who have had to rely on limited and unsafe crossing options. Inaugurating the project on Monday, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the nearly Rs.2-crore bridge would be completed within seven months and would improve connectivity between several densely populated neighbourhoods.

The footbridge will connect Gud Mandi, Rajpura, Roop Nagar, Mukherjee Nagar and the Yamuna route, providing a safer and more convenient crossing for students, senior citizens, office-goers and local residents who travel on foot every day. Addressing the gathering, Singh said the project fulfilled a long-pending public demand while reflecting the Delhi government’s focus on



strengthening civic infrastructure and ensuring public safety.

Referring to the bridge collapse reported in the city a few months ago, the minister said the incident underscored the need for regular structural assessments. He alleged that no comprehensive audit of bridges had been conducted under the previous government, leaving several important structures without proper safety evaluation.

“Today, we are conducting a city-wide audit of all bridges, flyovers and foot over bridges across Delhi to ensure public safety. At the same time, we are not waiting for problems to worsen. We sanctioned nearly

₹2 crore for this new footbridge in a short span of time, and work has now begun,” Singh said. He said the government was simultaneously addressing immediate infrastructure requirements while carrying out safety inspections across the city.

“The project is not merely about constructing a bridge but about restoring public confidence in Delhi’s infrastructure. Once completed, the footbridge will offer a secure and accessible passage, reduce inconvenience for pedestrians and improve connectivity between surrounding neighbourhoods,” the minister added.

According to the govern-

“The project is not merely about constructing a bridge but about restoring public confidence in Delhi’s infrastructure”

ment, the bridge is expected to significantly improve daily mobility, particularly for schoolchildren, elderly citizens and people who depend on walking to reach markets, public transport facilities and nearby residential areas.

Residents present at the inauguration welcomed the initiative, describing it as the fulfilment of a demand that had remained pending for years. The Delhi government said the project forms part of its broader effort to create safe, durable and people-centric infrastructure while addressing long-standing civic needs and improving the quality of life for people across the national capital.

CONTRACTS AWARDED TO FIRMS RELATED TO KIN OF CM KHANDU

SC summons Arunachal top officials over CBI’s non-cooperation claim in probe

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from the Arunachal Pradesh’s chief secretary and principal secretary (Home) after the CBI’s claim about “non-cooperation” by the state government in its inquiry into contracts awarded to firms allegedly related to the kin of Chief Minister Pema Khandu.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said both these officers would remain present before it on August 24 along with their responses to the CBI’s status report and also explain why there was non-cooperation.

On April 6, the apex court had directed the CBI to register within two weeks a preliminary enquiry into the allegations of preferential allotment of contracts for

public works in Arunachal Pradesh to firms allegedly owned or related to the family members of Chief Minister Khandu. The top court had directed the Arunachal Pradesh government and all its concerned departments, authorities and instrumentalities to cooperate fully with the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

On Monday, the bench perused the status report filed by the CBI. Additional Solicitor

General K M Nataraj, appearing for the CBI, said the probe agency has sought more time to complete the enquiry and the state authorities were not cooperating with it.

“We will call the chief secretary,” the bench observed, and said if there was non-cooperation then why a “long rope” was given. Referring to the CBI’s status report, the bench observed the probe agency has flagged certain discrepancies. “Why do you

need anything more for registering a RC (regular case),” the bench asked the law officer. It said the agency had sought some details from the state authorities which they have not provided.

“We have perused the status report given by the CBI dated July 17, 2026. A perusal of the same reflects that there is non-cooperation at the end of the state government in providing the necessary records...,” the bench said.

Gujarat: 22 children die of Chandipura virus this monsoon

‘Seven patients till under treatment in hospitals’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AHMEDABAD: As many as 22 children have died due to Chandipura virus (CHPV) in Gujarat this monsoon season, with 35 cases testing positive out of 184 suspected infections, State Health minister Praful Panseriya said on Monday.

Seven patients remain under treatment across civil hospitals in Gandhinagar, Rajkot, and other districts, and government and private paediatric facilities have been instructed to immediately

admit symptomatic patients to ICU beds to prevent organ failure, he said.

“A total of 184 suspected cases have been registered in the state so far, out of which 35 cases have tested positive and the results of 11 samples are still pending,” Panseriya said.

Out of the cases reported so far, 22 children have died due to Chandipura virus, he said. All patients are under 15 years of age, he added.

Children who are admitted to civil hospitals in Gandhinagar,

Sabarkantha-Himmatnagar, Patan, Rajkot and Bhavnagar are being provided the best and super-specialist treatment and doctors are monitoring their condition, Panseriya said.

He further noted that cases are being reported from different areas and not concentrated in a particular village.

Health teams are spraying pesticides in areas where animal husbandry is practised to target sandflies, which are responsible for spreading the encephalitis virus, he said.

From Page 1

Prashant Kishor

Throughout the campaign, Kishor projected the by-election as a “referendum on the Samrat Choudhary government”. His campaign focused heavily on employment, education and governance, with a special emphasis on first-time and Gen Z voters.

State BJP president Sanjay Saraogi said in a statement, “We bow before the will of the people. We shall draw lessons from the debacle, unlike our opponents who tend to blame every electoral loss of theirs on EVMs and the Election Commission”.

Kishor, 49, who had entered the fray announcing that he saw the by-election as a “referendum” on the BJP-led government in the state, told reporters, “The victory is a wake-up call for Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who must install a new chief minister in place of Samrat Choudhary, a man with criminal antecedents”.

Choudhary, who had joined the BJP less than a decade ago, was understood to have been picked up by the top leadership in line with the party’s attempts to win over non-Yadav OBCs in a state where the Mandal churn of the 1990s continues to cast a shadow on the political landscape. Choudhary succeeded Nitish Kumar, the JD(U) president who hung up his boots after a 20-year tenure as the Chief Minister.

However, Kishor, who had first shot to fame for handling Modi’s Lok Sabha campaign in 2014, was of the view: “Let there be another person from the Kushwaha community as the chief minister if the BJP wants it to be so. But he or she must be a decent person”.

“Bihar cannot be treated as a factory that produces cheap labour. I do not promise that my becoming the MLA will make Bankipur on par with Bengaluru. But, when Gujarat, the home state of Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, is looking forward to having a bullet train, the people of Bihar certainly have a right to expect something better than passenger trains,” said Kishor, amid screams of “Jai Bihar,” the Jan Suraj Party’s ubiquitous slogan, by supporters who had swarmed the streets.

Among those who turned up at the counting centre was Jahnvi Das, the doctor wife of Kishor, who is known to stay away from politics but had chosen to be by her husband’s side in his moment of glory. “This victory belongs to the people of Bihar,” said Das, who hails from Assam.

A pall of gloom seemed to have descended on the BJP camp. The exuberance on display in the morning, when hundreds of them turned up at a city-based sweets shop to pick up 200 kg of ‘laddoos’ they had ordered, expecting a certain victory, gave way to shock and despondency as the counting of votes proceeded and the lead enjoyed by Kishor grew almost progressively with every round.

Kishor’s victory was being hailed as “a lesson to the arrogant BJP” even by those outside his party, like Janshakti Janata Dal president Tej Pratap Yadav, the estranged elder son of RJD supremo Lalu Prasad, and CPI(ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhat-tacharya, whose party is an INDIA bloc partner.

The verdict in Bankipur must be viewed in the backdrop of the wider dissatisfaction with the BJP which recently got reflected in the students’ protests, said veteran socialist leader Shivanand Tiwari.

Nabin had won the seat for the fifth consecutive term in November last year and resigned in April this year following his election to the Rajya Sabha.

Jubilation erupted in the Jan Suraj Party camp, replacing the dejection that had set in after the fledgling outfit drew a blank in Assembly elections held in November last year.

Centre tells SC

The court then clarified that the National Capital Territory of Delhi and other states were at liberty to close or withdraw FIRs against protesters

through legally permissible means. It also clarified that the expression “criminal antecedents” referred only to persons involved in grave and heinous offences.

“It is clarified that NCT of Delhi and any other state shall be at liberty to close or withdraw FIRs against protesters... The word criminal antecedents is to be read as grave and heinous offences,” the Bench said.

Mehta said more than 2,700 protesters had been found to have criminal antecedents and that such cases would not be covered by the government’s commitment. He later clarified that the identification exercise relied not only on facial recognition but also on social media and other investigative tools.

Senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi sought clarification on the phrase “criminal antecedents”, arguing that students should not be denied relief because of traffic violations, petty offences or politically motivated cases. Accepting the concern, the court restricted the expression to grave and heinous offences.

Chief Justice Surya Kant also said the law must distinguish between genuine students and hardened criminals, while ensuring accountability for police personnel accused of misconduct.

“A police officer involved in excessive force should not be unduly protected. It should not be that a hardened criminal under the garb of student protest is also getting protected,” the CJI observed.

Senior advocate Vrinda Grover told the court that the issue extended beyond withdrawal of FIRs and concerned the future of thousands of young people.

“These are young people who have their lives ahead of them,” she said, adding that FIRs had been registered in Delhi, Bihar, West Bengal, Assam and Uttar Pradesh and that an appropriate legal mechanism would have to be worked out with the states.

The court was also hearing allegations of excessive force used during the July 20 Parliament march, when police dispersed protesters using lathis and teargas after they attempted to march towards Parliament.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan said more than 300 videos had been submitted to the court documenting the police action.

“The videos are very shocking,” he said, alleging that even lawyers’ children were assaulted and raising questions over the reported use of pellet guns.

Grover argued that Delhi Police had no standing order authorising the use of pellet guns for crowd control.

“The petition is not saying that the police should not have anything to protect itself. But this particular weapon is unfit for use,” she submitted.

Taking note of the allegations, the Supreme Court said it would constitute a high-powered committee headed by a former Supreme Court judge to investigate the incidents surrounding the July 20 protest. It also indicated that it intended to frame a protocol governing the use of pellet guns during public protests. The matter has been listed for further hearing later this month.

The petitions seek nationwide guidelines regulating police action during demonstrations, including safeguards on the use of force, restrictions on deploying plainclothes personnel for crowd control, regulation of prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, and an independent probe into the July 20 police action.

The court has earlier observed that police excesses or a lathi charge cannot be justified merely because a protest is taking place and has underlined that the right to peaceful protest is constitutionally guaranteed.

In a separate hearing on Monday, another bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe heard petitions seeking stronger safeguards against future NEET paper leaks.

Mehta informed the bench that the Centre wanted to place on record the entire process followed from printing NEET question papers until they reached candidates, along with the safeguards adopted at every stage.

The court accepted the request and posted the matter for hearing later this week after directing the Centre to file its affidavit.

The proceedings form part of a broader judicial review of reforms following the cancellation of the May 3 NEET-UG examination amid allegations of a paper leak. A fresh examina-

tion was conducted on June 21, while the Central Bureau of Investigation continues to investigate the leak allegations.

The Centre has informed the Supreme Court that it is preparing a comprehensive overhaul of the examination system, extending beyond the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan Committee constituted to reform the National Testing Agency and strengthen examination security.

The government has also set up a separate high-level task force headed by Nandan Nilekani to recommend measures for the proposed transition of NEET to an online format. The panel includes former ISRO chairman S. Somnath, former Intelligence Bureau director Tapan Deka, IIT Madras Director V. Kamakoti, former education secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

The student protests, which began at Jantar Mantar on June 20 and spread to several states, culminated in the July 20 march to Parliament. The agitation ended on July 25 after the government accepted key demands of the protesters and Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned.

Brij Bhushan

accused after finding a lack of evidence and accepting his arguments on “inconsistencies, contradictions, improbability and ground of alibi”.

Senior advocate Rebecca John, appearing for four of the complainants, questioned the claim, saying the detailed order was yet to be made available.

“How can he come to the conclusion that the court acquitted Brij Bhushan Singh based on inconsistencies by the complainant victims when the order is not available... and we are all waiting for the order?” she said, describing the acquittal as “deeply, deeply disturbing”.

Speaking to reporters outside the court, Singh said he had been “honourably” acquitted.

“On the first day, I had said that if any allegation against me was proved, I would hang myself. The court has now honourably acquitted me. I am happy and grateful to my lawyers,” he said.

“For now, this is all I can say. I will comment further after going through the court’s reasoned order,” the former BJP MP added.

Public prosecutor Manish Rawat said the prosecution would examine the detailed judgment before deciding on the next course of action before a higher court.

The allegations surfaced in April-May 2023 when women wrestlers staged a 36-day protest at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar, accusing Singh, then WFI chief, of sexually harassing women wrestlers. Vinesh Phogat, Sakshi Malik and Bajrang Punia led the protest.

Following a plea by seven wrestlers, the Supreme Court directed Delhi Police to register two FIRs against Singh.

Delhi Police later filed a chargesheet against Singh and Tomar under Sections 354 (assault or criminal force to a woman with intent to outrage her modesty), 354A (sexual harassment), 354D (stalking) and 506 (criminal intimidation) of the Indian Penal Code.

A separate FIR filed by a minor wrestler under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act was closed after the Delhi Police filed a cancellation report, which was accepted by a Delhi court in May 2025.

In May 2024, the trial court framed charges of sexual harassment, criminal intimidation and outraging the modesty of women against Singh and framed a charge of criminal intimidation against Tomar. Singh was discharged in one complaint filed by one of the six women wrestlers for lack of sufficient evidence.

The trial continued for more than two years through in-camera proceedings. Final arguments concluded on July 2, 2026, and the court had reserved its verdict for August 3.

Following the acquittal, several opposition leaders criticised the BJP government.

Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said, “On one hand they say that they are with the youth, there is talk of women’s empowerment and women’s reservation, and on the other hand there is this”

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Arvind Sawant alleged that when the women wrestlers were protesting, “not even women

BJP members went to sympathise with them.”

Section 498A

The bench also noted that no couple begins a relationship expecting cruelty, but some relationships take a difficult turn over time, and the law must be ready for that. It held that denying this protection to women in live-in relationships while granting it to married women has no real connection to the goal of preventing domestic violence and therefore goes against Article 14 of the Constitution, which guarantees equality.

At the same time, the court said safeguards against misuse, including checks on arrest, must still be followed strictly, and no one accused under this provision should be arrested without a preliminary inquiry.

Ram temple

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said two important bills were passed on Monday despite the opposition’s absence from the discussions. These included legislation increasing the strength of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38 and another relating to micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs).

“We urged everyone and I even asked Congress national president Mallikarjun Kharge ji to reason with his Congress MPs so they would at least participate in the bill discussion. But he couldn’t even manage his own Congress MPs,” Rijiju said. He also criticised Congress leader Rahul Gandhi for not attending the Lok Sabha proceedings, adding that the party had “completely fallen apart” and was refusing to participate even when important legislation was being considered.

Rijiju further said Congress leaders later claimed they were not being allowed to speak despite the government’s willingness to hold discussions. “I am deeply hurt. My biggest sorrow is that there is no one left to guide Congress MPs anymore,” he said.

Congress Deputy Leader in the Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi defended the opposition’s stand after attending the Lok Sabha BAC meeting. “Our demand is clear. PM Modi may have forgiven students, but the youth of the country have not forgiven the home minister,” he said, insisting Amit Shah should make a statement on the security forces’ action against protesting students. Gogoi also alleged that female students were being targeted online and questioned whether action would be taken against those revealing their personal details.

He said the opposition had consistently sought a discussion on the alleged diversion of crores of rupees in Ram temple donations to a VHP office. “If you can hold a discussion on the NEET examination, then you should also discuss the Ayodhya Ram Temple Trust,” Gogoi said, asking whether Prime Minister Narendra Modi would address the issue.

Amid the disruptions, the Lok Sabha passed the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026 without a debate before adjourning for the day. The Rajya Sabha also approved the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which aims to speed up settlement of delayed payments to MSMEs. The legislation allows courts to direct payment of at least 50 per cent of the awarded amount to MSME suppliers if an application challenging an order remains pending for more than six months. The Upper House was adjourned soon after the bill was passed.

Ready to apologise

The meeting followed the government’s decision to summon Meta’s senior executives after Prime Minister Modi’s Facebook post, in which he addressed India’s youth and promised strict action against paper leaks, was briefly restricted. Meta had earlier described the episode as a technical

error, apologised publicly and restored the post. However, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) termed the company’s explanation “inadequate”.

Sources said committee members also questioned the effectiveness of Meta’s algorithms in detecting deepfakes involving the prime minister. One member reportedly remarked that “if a video of the prime minister is not safe, then accountability needs to be fixed”.

Meta officials expressed regret before the panel and said they were prepared to apologise, sources said. A BJP MP, however, argued that an apology alone was insufficient and insisted that responsibility be fixed and legal action taken.

The meeting, chaired by BJP MP Nishikant Dubey, examined the subject “Social and Digital Platforms and their Regulation”. Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, MeitY Secretary S Krishnan and representatives of Meta, Google, X, Snapchat and YouTube attended the proceedings.

Several WhatsApp

facing the issue without any prior warning from the Meta group’s messaging app.

The WhatsApp app on the screen displayed the message: “Account in review. Date requested: 3 Aug 2026. Your account activity and device info is being checked to make sure it follows our terms of service. We will notify you of the result typically within 24 hours.”

Below these remarks, the app shows an option to learn about account issues, which include “How to use WhatsApp responsibly. See guidance” and an option “About stolen phone and accounts”.

Some of the users on social media posted different messages.

“My WhatsApp account has been disabled without any explanation. I have already submitted an appeal, but the review page only displays a generic message stating that it will “typically be reviewed within 24 hours. Help me urgently,” a user said on social media.

An account on X by the name of Saloni posted, “My WhatsApp account was suddenly disabled without any warning. I only use the official app, and my work depends on WhatsApp. Please help. This was so unnecessary.”

AGENCIES

Kerala rain

After chairing a joint emergency meeting of the State Disaster Management Authority, Satheesan said the government had reviewed conditions across all districts and launched preparedness measures even before the heavy rain began. Fourteen fishing boats from Kollam have been deployed to Chengannur for rescue work, while two helicopters from Sullur in Tamil Nadu have reached Thiruvananthapuram. Food packets have been readied for aerial and ground distribution.

As of 9 am on Monday, 316 relief camps were sheltering 11,018 people. One National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) team has been deployed in the affected area, with another in Pathanamthitta and two in Kottayam. Two additional NDRF teams have been sought from Arakkonam. The government has also directed that Indo-Tibetan Border Police personnel be deployed in Alappuzha, if required, and Defence Security Corps personnel be used in Kannur and Wayanad if the situation worsens.

The deaths include four in Malappuram, three in Kottayam, two each in Idukki and Kollam, and one each in Vizhinjam, Muthalappozhi, Kannur and Kozhikode. Kollam has reported two missing persons, Kannur two, Malappuram one, and one each from Vizhinjam and Muthalappozhi.

Preliminary estimates show crop damage across 164.98 hectares affecting 3,596 farmers, though Satheesan said the figures were expected to rise.

Rejecting rumours about water being released from major dams, the chief minister said all reservoirs remained within safe levels

and inspections were being carried out under the 2022 operational guidelines. “False reports claiming that water is being released from major reservoirs are creating unnecessary panic. Strict action will be taken against those spreading such rumours,” he said.

The government announced Rs 10,000 for funeral expenses for each deceased, Rs 8 lakh compensation to bereaved families, Rs 10,000 for families returning to flood-hit homes from relief camps, and Rs 300 per person, limited to two persons per ration card, for those who lost their livelihoods until normalcy returns. Assistance for families whose homes were completely destroyed in major landslides has been increased from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 12 lakh. Satheesan also said crop compensation would be revised upward after the next Cabinet meeting.

Calling it a “flash flood event”, Satheesan said the India Meteorological Department had not indicated such an extreme event until late Sunday night. Rainfall exceeded 300 mm in several places, with Vadaserikkara recording nearly 350 mm, leaving little time for evacuation despite overnight warnings, he said.

Govt moves

encourage foreign inflows, including the RBI’s swap facility for FCNR(B) deposits, external commercial borrowings by public sector undertakings and tax relief for FPIs investing in government securities.

Speaking after those measures were announced, Sitharaman had said the package was the “first step” to attract more foreign capital, adding, “We recognise we need more foreign capital to come in.”

Apart from easing norms for offshore funds, the Bill proposes tax exemption for foreign companies engaged in the storage and sale of electronic components through customs-bonded areas for supply to Indian manufacturers.

It also seeks to provide tax exemption until March 31, 2041, for eligible foreign entities engaged in the rough diamond trade on income earned from the sale of rough diamonds through notified special zones in India.

According to the Statement of Objects and Reasons, additional taxation measures are required to achieve the objectives of the June Ordinance more comprehensively in view of continuing global developments and stakeholder representations received after the enactment of the Finance Act, 2026.

The government said the measures are intended to mitigate the impact of external economic shocks, maintain domestic economic stability and support sectors affected by disruptions in global trade and supply chains.

Tax experts said the proposals could significantly improve India’s appeal as a destination for global fund management.

AKM Global Managing Partner Amit Maheshwari said simplifying the eligibility framework for offshore investment funds is expected to strengthen India’s attractiveness as a fund management jurisdiction and support the government’s goal of making India a competitive global investment hub.

EY India Partner and Financial Services Tax Leader Tejas Desai described the amendments as one of the most significant reforms for India’s fund management ecosystem in recent years, noting that only five of the original 13 qualifying conditions for eligible investment funds would remain.

Nangia Global Partner (M&A Tax) Abheet Sachdeva said the changes would enhance the attractiveness of India’s onshore fund management ecosystem and encourage more offshore fund management activities to shift to the country.

Grant Thornton Bharat Partner (Tax) Richa Sawhney said the Bill marks a shift from short-term relief to long-term competitiveness by combining tax certainty with incentives for investment, supply chains and strategic sectors.

CALLS FOR PATIENCE AS DISAPPOINTED ASPIRANTS TURNING RESTIVE

Karnataka CM Shivakumar unveils 19-member Cabinet expansion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: In the first expansion of the two-month-old Karnataka Cabinet led by Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, 19 MLAs were sworn-in as ministers on Monday, even as a Congress legislator resigned from his post over his exclusion from the ministry.

Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot administered the oath of office and secrecy to new Ministers in a ceremony held at the Lok Bhavan premises here.

The Congress legislators sworn in as ministers are P M Narendraswamy (Malavalli), Shivaraj Tangadagi (Kanak-agiri), Rudrappa Lamani (Haveri), K S Basavanthappa (Mayakonda), B Nagendra (Ballari rural), T Raghunurthy (Challakere), B Z Zameer Ahmed Khan (Chamarajpet), Rizwan Arshad (Shivajinagar), Santosh Lad (Kalaghatagi), Madhu Bangarappa (Soraba),



CM Shivakumar is greeted by Cabinet minister Ajay Singh after the swearing-in ceremony

Putturangashetty (Chamarajanagara), and S S Mallikarjun (Davangere North).
Ajay Singh (Jevargi), N Chaluvaraya Swamy (Nagamangala), K M Shivalinge Gowda (Arasikere), H C Balakrishna (Magadi), Basvaraj Rayareddi (Yelaburga), Vijayanand Kashappanavar (Bagal-akote), and Laxman Savadi (Athani) also took the oath.

Earlier in the day, AICC general secretary (Organisation) K C Venugopal sent a communication to Shivakumar regarding the Congress high command's approval of 20 names to be inducted into the Cabinet.

However, Gayathri Shanthegowda, an MLC, whose name was on the final list cleared by the Congress high

Highlights

» Gayathri Shanthegowda, an MLC, whose name was on the final list cleared by the Congress high command, was not sworn in on Monday, leaving the Karnataka Cabinet without a woman minister.

» Unhappy over being excluded from the cabinet expansion, Congress MLA from Indi, Yashavantarayagouda V Patil submitted his resignation from his legislative post on Monday

command, was not sworn in on Monday, leaving the Karnataka Cabinet without a woman minister.

Though it is unclear why Shanthegowda was not inducted into the Ministry at the last moment, party circles speculate that differences among state leaders regarding her selection caused it.

An earlier list included

Bhatkal MLA Mankala Vaidya, who was a minister in the Siddaramaiah cabinet, but he was subsequently replaced by S S Mallikarjun, also a former Minister.

No official reason has been cited for replacing Vaidya.

Shivakumar's cabinet colleagues, AICC General Secretary in-charge of Karnataka Ran-deep Singh Surjewala and state Congress President B K Hari-prasad attended the swearing-in. However, Siddaramaiah's absence was conspicuous.

With the long-awaited cabinet expansion finally materialising, it caused disgruntlement among the ruling Congress legislators, with a couple of ministerial aspirants who did not get a berth offering to resign. In fact, the MLA from Indi, Yashavantarayagouda V Patil submitted his resignation from his legislative post on Monday.

GHANSHYAM SINGH SECURED 66,757 VOTES

Congress retains MP's Datia seat, BJP suffers 2nd consecutive loss

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

sought to rally them behind the candidate.

The by-election witnessed an intense campaign, with both the BJP and the Congress deploying their top leadership. Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, Union Ministers Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Jyotiraditya Scindia, along with several senior BJP leaders, addressed public meetings in support of the party candidate. The Congress, too, mounted an aggressive campaign to reclaim the seat. Following the victory, Congress workers celebrated at the party's state headquarters in Bhopal, dancing to the beats of drums and hailing the result as a mandate against the BJP government.

State Congress president Jitu Patwari thanked the people of Datia, saying they had rejected the BJP government's "arrogance and corruption", while winning candidate Ghanshyam Singh credited voters and party workers for the victory. Although the by-poll involved only a single

Assembly constituency, political observers said the outcome carried wider political significance. Many believe the BJP's decision to replace Narottam Mishra, who had long been associated with the constituency, proved costly.

Datia had been regarded as Narottam Mishra's political bastion since 2008. Before his rise, the constituency had largely remained a Congress stronghold after its formation in 1952. The result also marks the BJP's second consecutive Assembly by-poll defeat in Madhya Pradesh, following its loss in the Vijaypur by-election, both in the Gwalior-Chambal region. The outcome is likely to pose fresh political questions for the ruling party ahead of the 2028 Assembly elections.

The Congress is expected to project the victory as evidence of growing public discontent with the BJP government, while the ruling party is likely to assess whether the defeat stemmed from local factors and candidate selection issues.

Bill to increase Supreme Court judges passed by Lok Sabha without debate

NEW DELHI: The Lok Sabha on Monday passed a bill to replace an ordinance that increased the number of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38 without a debate as opposition members persisted with slogan-shouting over the issues of NEET paper leak and alleged theft of Ram temple donations.

Last week, a Bill to amend the law on birth and death registration was also passed without any debate in the Lok Sabha under similar circumstances.

A statutory resolution moved by the opposition members denouncing the promulgation of the ordinance was also rejected by a voice vote.

After brief introductory remarks by Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal, the

As on January 1, this year, there were 92,101 cases pending in the Supreme Court

Chair urged the members to speak on the statutory resolution, but as sloganeering continued, the Bill was put to vote and subsequently cleared.

After the passage of the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, the House was adjourned for the day. The Bill was listed in the agenda almost every day since its introduction on July 20 but could not come up for consideration and passage.

The government has maintained that an enhanced strength is one of the most exigent and viable solutions for tackling pendency in the top court. In May, the Union Cabinet had cleared the Bill to increase the sanctioned strength of the top court, but soon the government brought an ordinance. After the ordinance, five judges were appointed based on the upgraded sanctioned strength.

After the ordinance was issued, the sanctioned strength went up to 38 from 34, including the CJL. According to the Bill, the volume of litigation in the Supreme Court has constantly been on the rise due to a gap between institution and final disposal of cases. **MPST**

PATNA: Prashant Kishor, who had scripted poll victories for leaders from Narendra Modi and Mamata Banerjee to Arvind Kejriwal, stunned the BJP in its Bankipur bastion, gaining a foothold for his Jan Suraj Party in the Bihar Assembly in his electoral debut.

The political strategist-turned-politician's victory in the Bankipur assembly bypoll was the culmination of his nearly two-year struggle during which he traversed the length and breadth of the state after launching Jan Suraj, before his outfit drew a blank in the Assembly polls last year.

Kishor has consistently maintained that in a country where a large section of the population struggles to make



Prashant Kishor celebrates with supporters

ends meet, there will always be space for a credible opposition.

"It is not the opposition, but the parties in the opposition that are weak in this country" has been one of the most insightful remarks of the I-PAC founder, whose prowess as a poll strategist benefited lead-

ers of as diverse hues as Modi, Banerjee, Kejriwal, Nitish Kumar, Jagan Mohan Reddy, Uddhav Thackeray and M K Stalin. With age very much on his side and the opposition INDIA bloc battered in Bihar, there is now a virgin territory for Kishor and his Jan Suraj

Party to explore.

But the Jan Suraj Party is not the first organisation in which he was active as a leader. His prowess in managing elections had endeared him to Nitish Kumar, who, after returning as chief minister in 2015, appointed him as an advisor with the rank of a cabinet minister. Three years later, he joined the JD(U) and quickly became the party's national vice president, triggering speculations that Kumar saw in him a successor to his own legacy. However, just over a year later, Kishor was ousted for openly lambasting Kumar's equivocal stand on the Citizenship Amendment Act, which had evoked protests in several parts of the country. **MPST**

BJP retains Manjalpur Assembly seat in Guj

MPST BUREAU

VADODARA: The BJP in Gujarat on Monday retained the Manjalpur assembly seat in Vadodara district, with the party candidate Satish Govindbhai Patel winning the bypoll, defeating his Congress challenger and former minister Bhikhabhai Rabari by 30,630 votes.

According to the Election Commission, Patel secured 55,481 votes, while Rabari polled 24,851 votes after all 20 rounds of counting were completed. Patel and Rabari were the only candidates in the fray in the saffron stronghold.

Notably, the BJP's margin of victory reduced in the current contest compared to 1,00,754 in the 2022 assembly elections, when the saffron party scored a record victory in Gujarat.

Thanking the voters after his victory, Patel, a former councillor of the Vadodara Municipal Corporation, said the people had once again reaffirmed their faith in the BJP.

His opponent, Rabari, a Gujarat vice president and former minister, alleged the misuse of government machinery to ensure his defeat.

Rabari alleged widespread violations of the model code of conduct during the poll campaign. Claiming that the election was not fought on a level playing field, the Congress leader said, "They (BJP) openly celebrated, beat drums and intimidated my workers, which affected voter turnout in my favour. I could not contest the election in the completely democratic manner in which it should have been fought. I have not received justice."

There was no immediate response from the BJP or the Election Commission on Rabari's allegations.

The bypoll, held on July 30, was necessitated by the death of senior BJP MLA and former Gujarat minister Yogesh Patel in June following a prolonged illness.

RS passes Bill to tackle payment delays faced by MSMEs amid protests

NEW DELHI: The Rajya Sabha on Monday passed a bill that seeks to tackle the issue of delayed payments to MSMEs by prescribing timelines to ensure faster adjudication of disputes, provide recovery of the settlement agreement, and address their liquidity issues, even as Opposition members continued to disrupt the House.

The Upper House was adjourned for the day soon after the passage of the Micro Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026, that seeks to empower courts to order payment of at least 50 per cent of the awarded amount to MSME suppliers, if the application to

set aside an order is pending for more than six months.

Members of the Opposition kept raising slogans throughout the discussion of the bill and later during its passage by voice vote. They were demanding the presence of Home Minister Amit Shah to answer questions on police action against students protesting the NEET exam paper leak and kept shouting slogans like "we want justice". Replying to the discussion on the bill, Union Minister for MSME Jitan Ram Manjhi outlined the advantages of the proposed legislation for the sector and various sections of society, and expressed dismay at the loud protests by Opposition members. "We expected our

opposition allies to support, cooperate, and pass this bill, but today they are opposing ... I am surprised, but despite this, I propose before the House that this bill be passed by amending the 2006 Act," said the minister.

The bill seeks to address the current challenges faced by the MSME sector by improving the administrative structure and facilitating payment mechanisms, he said.

"Its objective is to balance the interests of all concerned parties while maintaining constitutional principles and the interests of businesses," Manjhi said, reassuring the House that the government is committed to the development of the MSME sector. **AGENCIES**

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The government informed Lok Sabha that more than 1.18 lakh employees of the central government, both serving, newly recruited, and retired, have chosen to join the Unified Pension Scheme (UPS) as an alternate option under the National Pension Scheme (NPS), which provides an assured pension after retirement. In reply to a starred question posed by Janardan Singh Sigrwal, a member of the BJP in Lok Sabha, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, on Monday, stated that 1,18,195 individuals had enrolled in the scheme till July 19 this year.

The Unified Pension



Scheme, which was notified on January 24 last year, became effective from April 1, 2025. This scheme was aimed at addressing the longstanding demands of government employees enrolled in NPS for guaranteed income after retirement. Other than the existing employees who are enrolled on the scheme through the NPS, the scheme was also made available to employees who had

either superannuated or retired on or before March 31 last year, if they had served for at least 10 years. Eligible widows whose husbands were already dead and married in a legal marriage were also entitled to join the scheme.

The minister informed the government set up a deadline for the migration to the scheme, but after representations from the employees and the staff associations, the deadline was later extended to November 30, 2025. In response to queries about the performance of the scheme, Sitharaman informed the house that there had not been any evaluation of the scheme since it was just a year old.

Nation, identity and leadership: Mohan Bhagwat to engage in dialogue with Gen Z

RSS chief to interact with youth at I.I.M.U.N.'s 15th anniversary conclave on August 6

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

Key Points

» It is anticipated that approximately 2,000 students aged between 15 and 19 years from over 100 cities in the nation will participate in the event, which organisers term the world's biggest youth-run meeting

» The theme of the conference will be "The



Role of Youth in United the World, The Indian Way", bringing together students from schools and colleges to discuss both local, national, and international problems

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Founded in 2011 by Rishabh Shah, I.I.M.U.N. is an organisation that tries to promote leadership and civic par-

ticipation among young people. Over time, the organisation has organised several conferences and community services not only in India but abroad too; most activities are conducted by people aged between 15 and 24 years old. According to the founder, it became more and more significant to have a discussion between experienced leaders and young citizens at this important stage of development of India, and he is grateful to Bhagwat for accepting the

invitation.

The annual conference is seen as a platform where students can discuss the topic of governance, diplomacy, public policy and societal issues, according to the organisers of the program. Every year, there are more than a hundred conferences conducted by the organisation along with many civic engagements in which students from all over the country participate.

The I.I.M.U.N.'s Advisory Board consists of eminent people belonging to various backgrounds, including industrialist Ajay Piramal, industrialist Deepak Parekh, industrialist Nadir Godrej, MP Shashi Tharoor, former Chief Justice of India D. Y. Chandrachud, filmmaker Karan Johar and athlete P. T. Usha, among others.

As per the organisers, its programs have expanded to 275 cities across India and 40 countries, involving millions of youth through collaboration with schools, colleges and other community organisations. The

organisation has also hosted heads of state, Nobel laureates, artists, entrepreneurs and public personalities from across the globe throughout the years.

Generations Z and Alpha have lived in a social media-driven, artificial intelligence-based, globalised and instant communication world. Their perception regarding nationalism, identity, religion and citizenship varies greatly from those of preceding generations. This interaction gives RSS the chance to address youth directly rather than using any traditional means.

The younger generation is playing an increasingly important role in discussions about nationalism, politics, social justice, climate change and geopolitics. Each social, political and ideological organisation is trying to build itself up among youth. Through the programme, RSS can share their view on various matters, which will be responsible for shaping the future of India politically and socially.

'Population census in Ladakh, J&K, HP, Uttarakhand from Sep 1'

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Monday notified that the second phase of the ongoing Census -- population enumeration -- for Ladakh and snow-bound non-synchronous areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand shall take place from September 1 to 30.

In a gazette notification on Monday, Registrar General of India and Census Commissioner Mrityunjay Kumar Narayan said that conduct of Census of the population shall be undertaken in these regions from September 1 to 30 this year, with a revisional round from October 1 to 5.

"For the conduct of the above Census, there shall be an option for self-enumeration from August 17 to 31 just before the start of house-to-house population enumeration," it said.

The notification said the reference date for the Census in Ladakh and snow-bound non-synchronous areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand shall be 00.00 hours of October

1, 2026. The second phase population enumeration for the rest of the country is likely to begin next year.

The Census, the eighth since Independence, is being conducted in two phases, the first stage, known as house listing and housing census (HLO), and the second stage, the population census.

For the first time, caste details will also be collected during the population enumeration phase of the Census. The decision to include caste enumeration in the upcoming census was taken by the Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on April 30 last year.

The first phase -- house listing and housing census (HLO) -- is going on till September 30.

Field visits for the housing listing and housing census began on April 16 in several states and union territories. Enumerators will list all structures, houses and households across the country to create a foundation for population enumeration. **MPST**

CHARTS ORGANISATION'S FUTURE ROADMAP

CJP hails SC clarification on FIRs against NEET protesters

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) on Monday welcomed the Supreme Court's clarification on cases registered against students involved in the nationwide protests over the NEET paper leak, describing the development as a significant relief for young protesters.

The organisation also urged governments across states to act quickly and ensure that the court's observations are implemented without delay.

Addressing reporters, CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das said the apex court had made it clear that state governments are free to withdraw FIRs, file closure reports, or adopt any other legally permissible procedure to bring such cases to an end.

According to him, the clarification would prevent peaceful student protesters from facing long-term legal consequences.

Das also pointed out that the Supreme Court had explained the meaning of the term "criminal antecedents" used in its earlier order.

He said "the court specified that the expression applies only to individuals accused of seri-



CJP spokesperson Saurav Das addresses the media after a hearing over the recent NEET protests, at the Supreme Court, in New Delhi, Monday

Highlights

- » The organisation also urged govts across states to ensure that the court's observations are implemented without delay
- » Das also pointed out that the SC had explained meaning of term 'criminal antecedents'

ous offences such as murder or rape and not to students who had participated in protests or political demonstrations." He added that the organisation was awaiting the detailed written order but viewed the oral observations as a major victory for the student movement.

The clarification came during the hearing of petitions related to the police action against students who marched towards Parliament on July 20, demanding accountability over examination paper leaks and wider reforms in the country's examination system. The

protest, organised by the CJP after weeks of demonstrations and a hunger strike at Jantar Mantar, ended in clashes after police used tear gas and lathi-charge to disperse the crowd. While protesters alleged excessive force, Delhi Police maintained that action was taken only after some demonstrators turned violent.

Meanwhile, the CJP announced that its leadership will hold a two-day strategy meeting in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar beginning August 5 to decide the organisation's future roadmap.

The meeting will include founder Abhijeet Dipke, senior office-bearers and core volunteers who participated in the recent agitation.

Das said the organisation also plans to launch a nationwide listening tour to gather suggestions from young people following what it described as the successful campaign that culminated in the resignation of former Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Dipke, however, ruled out any possibility of transforming the organisation into a political party.

He argued that declining public trust in political institutions made a mass public movement more relevant than electoral politics.

Responding to questions over his education, Dipke said he was prepared to make public his scholarship and education loan documents related to his studies at Boston University.

He challenged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to similarly disclose his academic degree, asserting that his own overseas education had been financed through scholarships and an education loan.

Population Census in Ladakh, J&K, HP, U'khand from Sept 1

With a revisional round from October 1 to 5

OUR CORRESPONDENT

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Takeaways

- » The second phase of population enumeration for the rest of the country is likely to begin next year
- » The decadal exercise, scheduled for 2021, was postponed due to the COVID-19 outbreak
- » For the first time, caste details will also be collected during the population enumeration phase of the Census

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Field visits for the housing listing and housing census began on April 16 in several states and union territories. Enumerators will list all structures, houses and households across the country to create a foundation for population enumeration.

During the housing listing operations, enumerators physically visit each house and building and ask 33 questions regarding basic facilities in homes, details of the head of the household such as name and sex, ownership status and other information.

The decadal exercise, scheduled for 2021, was postponed due to the COVID-19 outbreak.

The Union Cabinet has approved Rs 11,718 crore for conducting the Census, which will be the biggest headcount exercise.

Oppn corners UP govt over Ram Temple donation theft

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council witnessed noisy scenes on the opening day of the Monsoon Session on Monday as the Opposition raised the alleged theft of donations from the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, forcing the Chair to adjourn proceedings for 15 minutes.

The Samajwadi Party moved an adjournment motion under Rule 105, alleging financial irregularities and corruption in connection with the alleged theft from donation boxes at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple.

As Leader of the House Keshav Prasad Maurya rose to respond, SP members trooped into the well of the House, raising slogans and demanding a detailed discussion on the issue.

With the uproar continuing, Chairman Manvendra Singh adjourned the House for 15 minutes.

Moving the adjournment motion, Leader of the Opposition Lal Bihari Yadav and SP member Kiran Pal Kashyap said stealing donations offered at a place of worship was a serious offence and alleged that the police investigation had been inadequate.

They claimed that only lower-level individuals had been proceeded against while a comprehensive and impartial probe had not been conducted.

Lal Bihari Yadav alleged that 12 of the 15 members of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust were associated with the RSS, while the remaining three represented the Uttar Pradesh government.

He claimed the absence of an independent investigation had led to public anger over the alleged theft.

CM Mann: Paper leaks shatter dreams of aspirants

Those claiming to make country Vishwaguru made mockery of edu system

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Standing firmly with Gen Z and raising its voice against what it termed as atrocities on the country's youth, the Punjab Vidhan Sabha on Monday passed a Censure Motion by voice vote against repeated paper leaks across the country.

Winding up the debate on the motion and later addressing the media, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann said repeated paper leaks under the BJP-led Union government had shattered the aspirations of crores of students, while those seeking justice were met with tear gas shells, pellet guns and police action instead of accountability.

The Chief Minister announced that the Punjab government would forward the Censure Motion to the Prime Minister's Office, the Union Ministry of Education and the Union Ministry of Home Affairs, urging the Centre to take stringent measures to prevent paper leaks and restore the credibility of the country's education system. Congress, however, walked out of the House during the debate



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann addresses the Vidhan Sabha

on the motion.

Addressing the Vidhan Sabha on Censure Motion against the repeated paper leaks in the country, CM Mann stated said, "Those who have been claiming to make the country a Vishwaguru have made a mockery of the education system by failing to check the repeated paper leaks across the country. Paper leaks, or in other words the selling of examination papers, shatter the dreams of the aspirants. A reflection of this is that 22 candidates of the NEET examination committed suicide. From 2014, ever since the BJP regime assumed charge of office, 93 paper leaks have taken place in the country."

HPSC playing with future of Haryanvi youth: Hooda

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda has stated that the Haryana Public Service Commission (HPSC) is playing with the future of Haryanvi youth.

"It appears that the BJP government in power has issued clear instructions to deliberately rig the recruitment process. Tactics such as paper leaks, copying of questions, and erroneous

questions and answers are used to stall recruitment for years, even when a recruitment process is finally completed after a long wait, the results are manipulated so that the majority of posts remain vacant. The recent PGT Computer Science result is a clear example of this," he said.

Hooda noted that applications were invited for 1,711 posts in this recruitment drive, which had been pending since 2019. "Now that the process was finally nearing completion, the

HPSC deliberately qualified only 1,101 out of 5,100 candidates. This means there is a strong likelihood that over 600 posts will remain vacant. Not only in the general category, but a large number of posts in reserved categories are also set to remain unfilled," he said.

The former Chief Minister stated that this was not the first time the BJP government has announced such results. "Time and again, across various recruitment drives, the pattern remains

the same: posts are either left vacant, or preference is given to candidates from other states over the people of Haryana," he noted.

Hooda stated that out of 613 posts for Assistant Professor (English), only 151 candidates were selected, leaving the remaining posts vacant. In a gross injustice to the DSC category, only one candidate was selected against 60 reserved seats, the remaining seats were left vacant citing the 35 per cent qualifying condition.

Haryana CM chairs SLC meeting to review development plans

For Narnaul, Narayangarh, Panipat and Kurukshetra

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday chaired a meeting of the State-Level Committee (SLC) at the Haryana Civil Secretariat to consider the draft development plans for Narayangarh-2031, Kurukshetra-2041, Narnaul-2041, and Panipat-2041.

The plans, prepared by the Department of Town and Country Planning, aim to promote planned land use, orderly urban growth and regulated building development across the state.

The Chief Minister directed officers to align all urban development plans with the vision of

Viksit Bharat-2047, ensuring that future planning adequately addresses projected population growth, modern urban infrastructure requirements, environmental sustainability, efficient transport systems and balanced urban expansion.

He further directed that adequate provisions be made for sewage treatment plants, water treatment facilities, power infrastructure, entertainment zones and other essential civic amenities so that residents do not face shortages of basic services in the future.

The Chief Minister was apprised that the development plan for Narayangarh has been prepared keeping in view a projected population of 95,000 by

2031.

The proposal envisages the development of six residential sectors and takes into account the growth opportunities arising from National Highway-72, expansion of industrial areas, conservation of the natural drainage system and the creation of green zones.

Saini directed that sufficient distance be maintained between industrial and residential areas to ensure a healthy and convenient living environment for residents.

Reviewing the draft plan for Kurukshetra, the Chief Minister emphasised that the district's religious and cultural significance should remain central to future development.

SKM plans nationwide protests from August 10

NEW DELHI: The Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) on Monday announced a phased nationwide agitation beginning August 10 and culminating in farmers' marches and multi-day mass actions on November 26 in Delhi and around 100 places across the country to press for its seven key demands.

SKM leaders said the agitation will begin with 'Jail Bharo', 'Rail Roko' and 'Road Roko' protests at over 1,000 locations, adding that they would continue until their demands are met.

Addressing a press conference here, SKM leaders said the programme was finalised at its All India Convention held in Delhi on July 28, attended by around 1,200 delegates, and the National Convention of Workers and Farmers on July 29, drawing nearly 5,000 leaders of trade unions and farmers' organisations.

SKM National Coordination Committee member Avik Saha said the farmers' body had spent the past five years trying to persuade the govt to honour the written assurances given after the repeal of the three farm laws, but without success.

Himachal Governor asks youth to lead PM Modi's Drug-Free India campaign

Urges youth to become champions of both environmental protection & fight against drug abuse

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta on Monday called for turning environmental conservation into a mass movement, saying every tree planted and nurtured today would stand as a living legacy for future generations.

He also urged the youth to become champions of both environmental protection and the fight against drug abuse.

The Governor was addressing a plantation drive organised under the campaign 'Har Ped, Himachal Ka Abhiman—Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' at APG Shimla University in collaboration with the Nishkam Srijan Foundation, here on Monday.

He said that institutions of higher education must become centres of sustainable development by instilling values of environmental stewardship and social responsibility among students.

The plantation should not be viewed as a symbolic exercise but as a long-term



commitment.

"The true success of a plantation campaign lies not merely in planting saplings but in ensuring that they grow into healthy trees," he said.

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's nationwide initiative 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam', the Governor said that the campaign beautifully connects environmental conservation with India's cultural values. "Just as a mother nur-

tures life, trees sustain life on Earth. Every sapling planted in the name of one's mother reflects gratitude towards motherhood, nature and the nation while strengthening our resolve to secure a greener future for generations to come," he observed.

The Governor also referred to the Prime Minister's Mission LIFE (Lifestyle for Environment) initiative, stating that environmentally respon-

Key Points

- » 'The true success of a plantation campaign lies not merely in planting saplings but in ensuring that they grow into healthy trees'
- » Gupta described India's youth as the nation's greatest strength
- » The plantation should not be viewed as a symbolic exercise but as a long-term commitment

sible lifestyle choices, including water conservation, reduced plastic use, energy efficiency, and tree plantation, could collectively make a significant contribution towards sustainable development.

Gupta described India's youth as the nation's greatest strength and urged them to adopt at least one sapling during their academic journey and nurture it into a full-

grown tree.

"Years later, when you return to your alma mater, that tree should stand as a living symbol of your commitment towards society and the environment," he said.

Drawing attention to another pressing national concern, Gupta welcomed the launch of the 'Nasha Mukh Yuva-Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' by the Prime Minister and appealed to young people to stay away from substance abuse and spread awareness about its harmful consequences.

He said that a developed India could only be realised through healthy, empowered, and socially responsible youth.

Earlier, the Governor planted a sapling under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign and interacted with students, faculty members, and volunteers participating in the plantation drive.

Gupta also distributed prizes to the winners of the poster-making competition.



Former WFI chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh after being acquitted by the Rouse Avenue Court, in New Delhi, Monday

a ticket from Kaiserganj and instead fielded his son, Karan Bhushan Singh. The decision was widely seen as an attempt to avoid political controversy while retaining the family's

influence in the constituency.

Karan Bhushan Singh went on to win the seat, indicating that the family's political network and Brij Bhushan's influence in the region remained largely intact despite the legal proceedings.

Political observers say Brij Bhushan never distanced himself from public life after being denied the ticket.

He remained active across the four districts of the Devipatan division, regularly attending public meetings, religious and social events, and maintaining contact with supporters. The large gathering of supporters at his Vishnoharpur residence after the court verdict has been viewed by many as not only a celebration of his acquittal but also a display of his continuing political support.

Nation Briefs

U'KHAND: ED ATTACHES RS 8.54 CRORE ASSETS OF ALLEGED BITCOIN FRAUDSTER

DEHRADUN: The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) has provisionally attached the property of the accused worth nearly Rs 8.54 crore in the alleged cryptocurrency fraud case of Hemant Ishwar Sharma, which took crores of people for a ride across the country. As per the information, the attachment of the assets came into place on July 31 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) 2002. The alleged Bitcoin fraudster runs an investment business based on an offshore crypto wallet BTCFUND.IS, which was registered in Iceland. The Enforcement Directorate has initiated the money laundering probe after registering First Information Reports (FIRs) by the Raipur Police Station, Dehradun, and Dineshpur Police Station, Udham Singh Nagar district, under various sections of the Indian Penal Code.

VICE ADMIRAL MANISH CHADHA TAKES CHARGE AS DG NAVAL OPERATIONS

NEW DELHI: Vice Admiral Manish Chadha, a communication and electronic warfare specialist, on Monday took charge as the new Director General Naval Operations (DGNO). In a distinguished career spanning over 35 years, the flag officer has held a wide range of command, operational, instructional, and staff appointments, both afloat and ashore. His key afloat appointments include command of Coast Guard Interceptor Boat CGS-05 and Indian Naval Ships Veer, Kirpan, and Mysore, the defence ministry said in a statement.



EDITORIAL

POLLUTED
PROGRESS?

India's latest ranking in the 2026 Environmental Performance Index (EPI) should not trigger either national self-flagellation or reflexive defensiveness. It should provoke something far more useful: honesty. Ranked 176th out of 177 countries, India remains among the world's poorest environmental performers despite climbing one place from the bottom. The temptation, as always, is to attack the methodology or celebrate the fact that the country is no longer last. Both responses miss the larger point. Global indices are not infallible. The EPI itself has acknowledged that its methodology evolves with every edition, making direct comparisons across years difficult, while the Government of India has repeatedly argued that the index underweights issues such as historical emissions, energy efficiency and ecosystem services. Yet even after accounting for these legitimate criticisms, the environmental realities confronting ordinary Indians remain undeniable. No ranking created in New Haven or New York invented Delhi's toxic winter smog, the drying of urban lakes, shrinking forests, disappearing wetlands or poisoned rivers. These are lived experiences. They are measurable in hospital admissions, declining agricultural productivity and mounting climate-related disasters. The debate, therefore, should not be about whether India deserved to be ranked 176th or 150th. It should be about why environmental degradation has become so deeply embedded in the country's development model.

The report's greatest value lies not in the overall ranking but in what it reveals about the breadth of India's environmental challenge. Air pollution continues to define the country's environmental health crisis. Every winter, large parts of the Indo-Gangetic Plain witness particulate matter concentrations several times higher than World Health Organisation guidelines, while industrial emissions, thermal power plants, construction dust, crop residue burning and exploding vehicle ownership combine to produce an almost permanent public health emergency. Simultaneously, groundwater depletion continues across major agricultural states, rivers remain burdened by untreated sewage and industrial effluents, and municipal solid waste management struggles to keep pace with rapid urbanisation. Forest fragmentation driven by highways, mining and infrastructure expansion weakens biodiversity even as climate change intensifies heatwaves, floods and erratic monsoons. These are not isolated policy failures but interconnected governance failures. Environmental regulation remains fragmented across ministries, pollution control boards continue to face shortages of staff and scientific capacity, and enforcement often gives way to post-facto clearances or lengthy litigation. Environmental impact assessments are increasingly becoming procedural exercises rather than rigorous decision-making tools. Economic growth has understandably become India's foremost priority, but growth that steadily erodes natural capital ultimately undermines the very prosperity it seeks to create. Healthy ecosystems are not obstacles to development; they are infrastructure every bit as essential as highways, ports and power plants.

At the same time, the EPI should not be treated as the final word on India's environmental performance. Its methodology has long attracted criticism for favouring present-state outcomes over developmental trajectories and for inadequately accounting for historical responsibility in global emissions. India's per capita emissions remain substantially below those of most developed economies even as it seeks to lift millions out of poverty. The country has also undertaken genuine climate initiatives: renewable energy capacity has expanded dramatically, solar parks have multiplied, LED lighting programmes have reduced electricity demand, ethanol blending has increased, and ambitious targets have been announced for non-fossil electricity generation and net-zero emissions by 2070. Yet these achievements cannot obscure a difficult reality. Renewable energy is being added without a proportionate reduction in coal dependence because overall electricity demand continues to surge. Cleaner cooking fuel has reduced indoor pollution for millions of households, but worsening outdoor pollution often cancels out these gains. Environmental governance cannot succeed through announcements alone. It requires stronger institutions, credible monitoring, transparent data, scientific regulation and political willingness to enforce laws even when doing so inconveniences powerful economic interests. Countries with comparable or lower income levels have demonstrated that stronger environmental outcomes are possible through better governance, municipal capacity and regulatory enforcement. The lesson is not that India has failed to develop; it is that development without environmental safeguards eventually becomes self-defeating.

India today stands at a defining moment in its developmental journey. It seeks to become the world's third-largest economy, a global manufacturing hub and a leading voice of the Global South. None of these ambitions are incompatible with environmental stewardship. In fact, they increasingly depend upon it. Investors now evaluate environmental resilience alongside financial risk. Global supply chains increasingly demand cleaner production. Citizens are becoming less willing to accept polluted air and contaminated water as inevitable costs of progress. Climate change is no longer a distant ecological concern but an economic challenge affecting food security, labour productivity, public health and fiscal stability. The real question, therefore, is not whether India can improve its position in the next Environmental Performance Index. Rankings rise and fall. The real question is whether every Indian child will inherit cleaner air than their parents breathed, whether rivers will support life rather than carry waste, whether forests will remain ecological assets rather than isolated fragments, and whether development will be measured not merely by kilometres of highways built but also by the quality of life they sustain. Environmental policy must move from being treated as a regulatory hurdle to becoming a central pillar of economic planning. If India wishes to lead the twenty-first century, it cannot merely aspire to become an economic superpower. It must also demonstrate that rapid growth and environmental responsibility can advance together. That is the only ranking that will truly matter.

PART II



ANIRBAN GANGULY

THE WRITER IS A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE (NEC), BJP, AND THE CHAIRMAN OF DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE RESEARCH FOUNDATION

Drawing on Sri Aurobindo, Vivekananda, Sree Narayana Guru and Ambedkar's ideals, India's rise requires service, social cohesion and constitutional methods above confrontation

The Viswaguru Imperative

The idea of India as Viswaguru demands discipline, constitutionalism and national purpose—not rhetoric, disruption or the politics of anarchy



Drawing on the lives and ideas of Sri Aurobindo, Swami Vivekananda, Sree Narayana Guru and Babasaheb Ambedkar, India's rise must rest on constitutional methods

A glimpse of what it takes to transform India into *Viswaguru* was seen during the dark days of the pandemic, when Covid inundated the world and India stood out, radiating hope and succour. The Modi abusers had then taken the Indian vaccine, which Modi took first to reassure us all that it was India-made and safe. It saved India; it saved Modi's haters and abusers. In developing one of the most effective vaccines, India outpaced many so-called developed nations and leading superpowers of the world. In keeping with her ideal of "Viswamitra", India also supplied vaccines to a large number of smaller nations that had been left in the lurch by bigger powers. How can those who claim to know how to turn India into *Viswaguru* today forget those dark and uncertain days and the light shown then by Modi's leadership?

Another glimpse of India's potential to become *Viswaguru* was repeatedly seen over the last twelve years, when Modi ensured that Indians and Indian students were rescued to safety from war zones and difficult terrain. Operation Sindhu, in June 2025, evacuated 110 Indian students to safety from the Iran-Israel conflict zone. Another 290 MBBS students, mostly from Jammu & Kashmir and studying medicine in Iran, were evacuated in June 2025. The Vande Bharat Mission during the Covid period saw a large number of Indians being brought back to the country, with over 1.83 crore Indians having their travel facilitated. Operation Ganga, in February-March 2022, saw over 18,000 Indian nationals, mainly students, evacuated from Ukraine through 90 flights.

Sri Aurobindo renounced politics in his thirties and took to the path of his *sadhana* for India's regeneration and human transformation. Swami Vivekananda was twenty-nine when he plunged into the sea at Kanyakumari and swam across the shark-infested stretch to meditate on the last rock at the confluence of the three seas, at the end of his countrywide travels as a *parivrajak*. It was here, while meditating on the plight of his countrymen and compatriots, who were downtrodden and under subjection, that he evolved a plan for India's regeneration and went on to generate a storm in both the West and India.

When Nanu Swami transformed into Sree Narayana Guru, descending from his intense penance on the Maruthwamala Hills, he was thirty-one. It was as Sree Narayana Guru that he founded the Sivagiri Mutt and led the historic and transformative educational, social and religious reform movement that has left a lasting and living imprint on the national psyche.

Each of these stalwarts represented Indian youth and was seen as a voice of liberation in his lifetime. Why were posters of Sree Narayana Guru, Sri Aurobindo, Swami Vivekananda and Mahatma Jyotiba Phule—all educational and social reformers, revolutionary thinkers and men of action in their era—missing from Jantar Mantar? Why were the images of Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Raja Rammohun Roy, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose and Mahakavi Subramania Bharati missing from the protest venue?

Is it because these personalities represented a line of thought and action centred on India's rise and greatness? Was it because each of these icons embodied a duty-driven patriotism, an India-centred nationalism and a

vision of social transformation? Was it because they spoke of strengthening India through social cohesion and national unity?

Those who professed to speak at the venue in the name of Babasaheb Ambedkar's political and social philosophy were, in fact, betraying him. By pushing for the uprooting of the Indian Parliament, by negating constitutional methods, by calling for Modi's death, by abusing his late mother, and by demanding that Modi be hanged, they were, in effect, advancing the "Grammar of Anarchy". Babasaheb Ambedkar had warned against this tendency as early as 25 November 1949, in his final speech in the Constituent Assembly, when his mind "was so full of the future of our country."

Cautioning against losing our independence once again through the "treachery and infidelity" of our own people, Babasaheb articulated his fundamental dictum—his philosophy on how to preserve India as a democracy "not merely in form, but also in fact." "The first thing we must do is to hold fast to Constitutional methods of achieving our social and economic objectives. It means we must abandon the bloody methods of revolution... Where constitutional

methods are open, there can be no justification for these unconstitutional methods. These methods are nothing but the *Grammar of Anarchy*, and the sooner they are abandoned, the better for us."

Which icons do the Modi abusers, whom some tell us can make India *Viswaguru*, then follow or draw inspiration from? They reject Sri Aurobindo, remain silent on Vivekananda, and have betrayed Ambedkar. Who, then, are their idols?

Self-styled Sri Aurobindo experts who pat the self-styled Gen Z Modi abusers on the back and repose faith in their ability to make India *Viswaguru* must instead ask them to read, absorb and internalise, if at all possible, Sri Aurobindo's advice to the students of the National College. His appeal to them to "Work that she [India] may prosper. Suffer that she [India] may rejoice..." remains relevant and striking across generations and decades.

That appeal, that earnest injunction, is the surest recipe, formula and ideal for India's rise. It is the only counter to the *Grammar of Anarchy* and its false harbingers. It is the only authentic way for India to become *Viswaguru*.

Views expressed are personal

REGIONAL
FOCUS



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT, AND A FORMER NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR IN MAURITIUS

Her proposed December return raises questions over accountability, political rehabilitation, public sentiment, and Bangladesh's fragile post-uprising political landscape

Hasina's Homecoming Gamble

Beyond Sheikh Hasina's personal decision lies a larger contest over justice, democratic legitimacy, political inclusion, and whether Bangladesh is prepared to move beyond the divisions created by the 2024 uprising

Deposed Prime Minister of Bangladesh, Sheikh Hasina, sent ripples with her recent announcement that she plans to return to Bangladesh next December and surrender before the Court. She made a similar call to her party leaders living in exile to return to the country along with her. Her sudden disclosure, contrary to any prior indications, has startled Bangladesh watchers. Speculation is rife over whether she would actually return or whether this is a move to send feelers to elicit reactions in Bangladesh. Experts believe she has sent up a trial balloon and, therefore, it is still not clear whether she would actually return. She must have also anticipated that there is a likelihood of many political developments unfolding till December, when she plans to return. In sum, there is a big question mark, as of now, over her return. Sheikh Hasina disclosed her return plans in a telephone interview with the UK-based news agency Reuters. During the interview, she specifically stated that she intends to return to Bangladesh next December.

Many in Bangladesh reckon that there is uncertainty even within the Awami League (AL) about whether this is a genuine plan or a political strategy to revive the party's activities. Many party leaders also say that, beyond the question of whether Sheikh Hasina herself will return, the bigger issue is how many leaders and activists would ultimately be willing to risk returning under the current political circumstances. Significantly, public ire against Hasina is still prevalent in many quarters and, judging by this, a hasty return would certainly mean certain doom for Hasina.

Sheikh Hasina further said that she and other AL leaders wanted to return to Bangladesh voluntarily and surrender before the courts. She even said: "I have to return. My party's leaders and activists are facing severe repression. If death comes, I want to die on my own soil—where my parents are buried and where their blood was shed." However, according to senior AL leaders, the December timeline may also be symbolic. It could be part of a well-crafted strategy to energise party members, build pressure for the lifting of the ban on the party, and reclaim political space. Interestingly, after the news of Sheikh Hasina's announcement that she would return to Bangladesh became public, many AL leaders said they were unaware of any concrete political strategy or preparations behind this dramatic announcement.



As Bangladesh marks two years since the uprising, Hasina's return announcement has reopened unresolved political and legal questions

Also, with nearly five months remaining before December, much will depend on the country's political situation, the position of the ruling BNP government, the attitudes of opposition parties such as Jamaat-e-Islami (JI) and the National Citizen Party (NCP), and the role of the international community. A senior AL leader, speaking to a section of the Bangladesh media on condition of anonymity, revealed that Sheikh Hasina has been the party's president for 44 years and maintains extensive international connections. She is also fully aware of the party's current fragile condition. Nevertheless, since she has publicly stated that she will return, she may have her own preparations in place. However, the dynamics of her return remain vague.

In the meantime, many party members who have substantial financial resources are unlikely to return to Bangladesh and face imprisonment simply because Sheikh Hasina has called on them to do so. They are more likely to "wait and watch" until the political scene becomes more favourable, the chances of which look remote. As a result, although Sheikh Hasina's announcement may inspire strong emotions among party members, there remains uncertainty over whether it will lead to a large-scale collective return. Meanwhile, Bangladesh is marking the second anniversary of the student-led mass uprising. Against this backdrop, Sheikh Hasina's remarks about her return have already generated political reactions within the country. Political analysts believe that the timing of her announcement was influenced by

the anniversary of the uprising as well as Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) Acting Chairman Tarique Rahman's visit to China.

In another extradition-related development, the Bangladesh government is formally seeking India's cooperation to secure the extradition of former Home Minister Asaduzzaman Khan Kamal, who has been sentenced to death by the International Crimes Tribunal (ICT) for crimes against humanity committed during the July uprising in 2024. Asaduzzaman, along with many other AL leaders, including deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, fled to India in the wake of the July uprising. The Home Ministry sent the relevant documents to the Foreign Ministry on July 17, requesting that the matter be taken up with New Delhi. The request includes details of the ICT verdict, pending criminal cases against him, and a recently approved Anti-Corruption Commission charge sheet filed against the former minister. Here, it is relevant to mention that Bangladesh and India signed an extradition treaty in 2013, which was amended in 2016. However, it states that "extradition may be refused if the offence for which it is requested is an offence of a political character."

Avinash Paliwal, a professor at SOAS University of London, in the meantime, opines that Hasina's announcement offers an opportunity to unpack the political undercurrents in Dhaka. The party remains banned and has lost a chunk of its voter base to the ruling BNP in the February elections. It still retains pockets of scattered support but does not have a clear roadmap for returning to mainstream politics.

Interestingly, the BNP itself has diverse views on the AL's return. The pragmatist view, held by party seniors and Cabinet ministers, including Salahuddin Ahmed and others, is to allow the reformists within the AL to stage a comeback. Such a move is likely to prevent the JI-NCP coalition from expanding its political footprint while allowing the BNP to manipulate a weaker AL for its benefit. This view likely has Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's sympathy. But the hardline view, held by the BNP's younger cadre and mid-level leadership, is to maintain the ban on the AL. From their vantage point, the AL's return risks destabilising the streets and increasing local-level competition.

The JI and NCP's aversion to the AL is visceral. If the students faced bullets in July 2024, the JI has a longer history of persecution under Hasina. But what irks these parties most about the idea of the AL's return is the prospect of losing whatever little they have gained since Hasina's ouster. They realise that Islamist politics in Bangladesh has limited electoral appeal and that the BNP remains deeply entrenched. This is why they do not intend to waste limited political capital on protests during the first half of the BNP's term. But they are also aware that, if it comes to pass, a BNP-enabled, reformist-led AL will become an immediate threat to the JI-NCP coalition. In that situation, these parties will take to the streets with intent, leading to a political crisis. Further, according to Paliwal, Hasina's announcement underlines that there is an urgent need for Bangladeshi parties to rethink their political culture and make space for reconciliation.

That Hasina's possible return could trigger a crisis is understandable. But it also offers an opportunity—a chance to hold a fair and open trial that not only holds her to account but also impresses upon her the reality of what people truly think about her. Dhaka, as Paliwal argues, has a choice to make: to let Hasina destabilise the country again or to use her return as a starting point for national healing and reconciliation. What it must not do is delude itself into believing that the consensus to prevent the AL's return will wish the problem away. The AL's ouster from Bangladeshi politics is unsustainable. The only question is how to curate its return as an opportunity rather than a risk. This view could, prima facie, appear far-fetched, but it cannot be altogether dismissed.

Views expressed are personal

THE TALKS SUPPOSED TO SEEK TO END THE CONFLICT

No talks under way with US, says Iran after Trump calls off attacks

DUBAI/WASHINGTON: Iran said on Monday there were no talks under way with the United States and no plans for any meetings, contradicting U.S. President Donald Trump, who had cited talks he said would take place that afternoon as justification for calling off attacks. Tehran's statement was reported by Reuters.

US President Donald Trump said new talks to wind down the war in Iran will start Monday, after announcing he is holding off on new massive strikes he had threatened to unleash on the country.

The talks will seek to end the conflict and revive stalled cargo traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial waterway through which about a fifth of all traded oil and natural gas passed before the war.

Iranian state media quoted the country's foreign ministry as saying Tehran was not currently holding negotiations with the United States.

Elsewhere, Israel struck the Gaza Strip over the weekend,



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

days after the US and Hamas said a deal was reached for the militant group to disarm, a potential step toward ending the war in Gaza.

Hospitals in Gaza said at

least 17 people were killed in the weekend strikes, including children. A strike on a residential apartment in southern Gaza killed three family members, including a 4-year-old

child, according to Nasser hospital, where the bodies arrived.

The Israeli military said the strikes targeted militants.

Trump said Sunday that he decided against carrying out

Highlights

- » Trump says negotiation with Iran to begin on Monday
- » Trump has repeatedly announced attacks only to back down
- » The Israeli military said the strikes in Gaza targeted militants

major strikes against Iran at the urging of Gulf allies Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates. He said a plan was in place for US forces to carry out "the biggest attack since World War II," but he decided to give diplomacy more time after hearing from key Gulf leaders, as well as at the request of unnamed Iranian officials. "Now what we're doing is we're talking to them in the form of a negotiation. It begins tomorrow afternoon," he said. He did not provide further details or say who would be involved in the talks. AGENCIES

Sharif's PML-N set to form government in PoK

Sweeps 2nd phase polls amid violence, rigging allegations

LAHORE: The Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) swept the second phase of elections in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), winning 14 out of 18 contested seats, which will enable it to form a government in the region.

The Pakistan People's Party won the remaining four seats, PoK's Election Commissioner Ghulam Mustafa Mughal said on Monday.

The second phase of the ongoing PoK polls was held on Sunday, amid violence and rigging allegations.

One person was killed, and several were injured in the violence.

Mughal said polling in three more seats, which were supposed to happen on Sunday, will now take place on Tuesday.

"Polling staff and election material could not reach the constituency because of landslides and bad weather that resulted in blocked roads."

The elections for 45 contesting seats in the so-called legislative assembly in PoK are happening in three phases between July 27 and August 10.



Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif

The elections for 45 contesting seats in legislative assembly in PoK are happening in three phases between July 27 & Aug 10

India maintains that the entire Union Territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable parts of it.

New Delhi also asserts that Pakistan has been in "illegal and forcible occupation" of parts of these

Union Territories.

Last week, India described the ongoing elections in PoK as an attempt by Islamabad to camouflage its illegal occupation and hide its "grave" human rights violations in the region.

"The current cosmetic electoral exercise is nothing but an attempt by Pakistan to camouflage its illegal occupation and hide its grave human rights violations in the region," External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in New Delhi.

In the first phase held on July 27, the establishment-backed Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) won nine out of 13 seats, while the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) won the rest.

With the two phases taken together, PML-N has won 23 seats - the majority mark out of the 45 contested seats, even as another phase of the polls is yet to be held.

The PML-N, led by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and his brother Nawaz Sharif, are coalition partners of the PPP in the federal government. AGENCIES

Russia blasts Ukrainian city with glide bombs; Kyiv drones kill nine

KYIV: Russian planes dropped eight powerful glide bombs in a span of 90 minutes on residential districts of the southern Ukrainian city of Zaporizhzhia, killing one person and wounding dozens of others, regional chief Ivan Fedorov said Monday.

Meanwhile, six people were killed by Ukrainian drone debris in Arkhipo-Osipovka, a small town on Russia's Black Sea coast in the Krasnodar region, regional governor Veniamin Kondratyev said, adding that 40 others were wounded.

Three other people were

Key Points

- » Neither side's claims could be independently verified
- » The peninsula's Russian-installed head, Sergei Aksyonov gave no details
- » Under the deals, Ukraine receives funding for its defence industry

killed and two were wounded in Ukraine's overnight attack on the illegally annexed Crimea, said the peninsula's Russian-installed head, Sergei Aksyonov.

He gave no details.

Neither side's claims could be independently verified.

Ukraine's innovative long-range drone technology developed during the war has enabled Kyiv to sign military cooperation agreements with nine countries, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Monday.

Under the deals, Ukraine receives long-term funding for its defence industry while partner countries get new defence capabilities, he said, adding that agreements with 15 other countries are being negotiated. AGENCIES

PM visits quake-hit southern Japan

TOKYO: Residents in Japan's quake-hit southwestern prefecture of Kumamoto put out heaps of debris for collection as the region baked under intense heat.

The heat and a lack of water supplies have added to the challenges in the severely damaged areas where Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi briefly visited for the first time since a magnitude 7.1 quake hit Kumamoto Prefecture on Japan's southern main island of Kyushu on Tuesday. Thirty-eight people died during the quake, including one who died of apparent heat stroke while taking shelter in a car in hot weather and one other whose cause of death is still being investigated, prefectural officials said Monday.

Residents put out heaps of debris, broken furniture and damaged appliances for collection, while in the towns



Cars move to the wrong lane to avoid a damaged building that fell on the street in Yatsushiro

of Uki and Hikawa, construction of temporary housing began. Some hotels and inns are offering their rooms for evacuees. AGENCIES

INDONESIAN FERRY FIRE

Unknown number of people still missing

SURABAYA: Indonesian rescuers searched for possible missing passengers Monday after rescuing 231 people from a ferry that caught fire the previous day off the main island of Java, leaving at least five people dead. Passengers described leaping overboard and staying afloat for hours before rescue.

The Mutiara Sentosa 2 ferry was travelling from Indonesia's second-largest city of Surabaya in East Java to the city of Makassar in South Sulawesi. Initial reports said it was carrying 271 people, including 39

crew members, based on the ship's manifest, when the fire broke out between 6 am and 7 am.

However, by Monday officials said many more people were aboard than listed, and the number of people missing was unclear. Officials were relying on reports from families of victims and survivors in an attempt to determine the number of the missing.

It is common in Indonesia for the number of passengers on a boat or ferry to differ from the manifest. AGENCIES

Government of Jharkhand Rural Works Department
JHARKHAND STATE RURAL ROADS DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY (JSRRDA)
FFP Building, 3rd Floor, Dhurwa, Ranchi-834004

Tender No 22
The undersigned on behalf of Government of Jharkhand invites quotation for **Forest Diversion/ Clearance proposal including clearance of all stages as required** (General Forest/ Wild Life by DFO, CF, CCF, PCCF Level & Up to Wild Life board in JSRRDA for Rural Road Construction under PMGSY/RCPLWEA/PM-JANMAN) of reputed Firm / Consultant.

The quotation can be submitted in sealed envelope addressed to undersigned on or before the 10.08.2026 time 5.00 PM mentioned to JSRRDA, 3rd Floor, FFP Building, Dhurwa, Ranchi-834004 (JHARKHAND) by hand or by Post / Courier

Any offer received after the date and time of submission will not be considered. Department will not be responsible for any delay caused by post office or courier service provide.

The decision taken by the department will be final and binding upon the quotationers and no correspondence regarding this issue will be entertained.

The department reserves right to accept or reject any / all quotations or to place order to one or multiple quotationers.

Financial proposal/ Bill of quantities for Per Project bids:-

Sl.No.	Description of item (with brief specification and reference to book of specifications)	Amount	
		In figure	In word
1.	Consultancy service fee for Forest Clearance Related Works (Per project) if more than five hectre.		
2	Consultancy service fee for Forest Clearance Related Works (Per project) if less than one hectre.		
3	Consultancy service fee for Forest Clearance Related Works (Per project) if more than one hectre and less than 5 hectre.		
4	Consultancy service fee for Forest Clearance Related Works (Per project) in case of Wild Life Sanctuary forest area (more/less than one hectre)		

Sd/-(Manohar Kumar)
PR 386518 (Rural Work Department)26-27*D
Engineer-in-Chief JSRRDA, Ranchi.

UNITED TERRITORY OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PMGSY CIRCLE BATOTE.
SHORT NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS
E-NIT NO:-PMGSY/SE/B/22 OF 2026-27 DATED:- 01/08/2026

Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote on behalf of The Government of Jammu & Kashmir, invites e-tenders on %age Above/Excess (+) OR %age Below/ Less (-) basis (i.e. on Percentage-Rate Basis) from approved and eligible Contractors registered with J&K U.T.Govt, CPWD, Railways or equivalent and other State/U.T.Govts up to 1700 Hrs. On 14-08-2026 for each of the following works.

S. No.	Name of Work	Estimate d Cost (in Lacs)	Earnest Money (in Lacs)	Cost of document	Time of completion (in days)	Date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	Permanent restoration of Bhagwah to Dessa Package No. JK04-219, Doda to Bhagwah Package No. JK04-316, Chilli Dhandal Part-I Package No. JK04-223, Chilli Dhandal Part-II Package No. JK04-328, Doda Gaddi Package No. JK04-219, Saras to Kastigarh Package No. JK04-172, Dangrota to Ganika Package No. JK04-305 & Beoli to Bijarni JK04-187, District Doda.	265.00	5.30	10000	180 days	On or after 17/08/2026 at 11:00 AM	A

Position of AAA & TS = Accorded

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen / downloaded from the departmental website www.pmgstendersjk.gov.in as per below schedule.

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	01/08/2026 (1400 Hrs)
2	Period of Downloading of bidding documents	From 01/08/2026 (1600 Hrs) to 20/08/2026, (1700 Hrs.)
3	Date time and place of pre-bid meeting	03/08/2026 (1200 Hrs) - Office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote
4	Bid Submission Start Date	03/08/2026, (1600 Hrs.)
5	Bid Submission End Date	14/08/2026, (1700 Hrs.)
6	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bids (Online)	17/08/2026 on or after 1100 Hrs. in the Office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote
7	Date & Time of Opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after Technical bid evaluation is completed

-Sd-
No: PMGSY/SE/B/3186-3260
Dated: 01-08-2026
Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote
For and on behalf of The Government of Jammu and Kashmir
DIP No:DIP/J-7195/26

Michigan reports first 2 US deaths of cyclospora

LANSING: Two people have died in the cyclospora outbreak in Michigan in the first confirmed deaths in the US related to the microscopic parasite, state health officials announced Monday.

The Michigan Department of Health and Human Services said both people had underlying health conditions that may have been impacted by the intestinal illness and dehydration.

The department said it will not be providing additional information about the deaths. AGENCIES

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Nirmal Sikka, wife of Late Shri J.S. Sikka, resident of B-4/151, Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi - 110029 hereby inform the general public that: My daughter-in-law Amita Sikka and her three children constantly misbehave with me and with my unmarried daughter, and threaten to kill us. My son Vikas Sikka is unable to help me in any of these matters. For the above reasons, I, with effect from today's date, hereby completely disown/dishonor Vikas Sikka, his wife Amita Sikka, and their children from all my movable and immovable property. From today onwards, I and my family shall have no relation, transaction, or liability whatsoever with the above-mentioned persons. They shall have no right over any of my property. If any person/institution enters into any transaction with the above-mentioned persons, they shall do so at their own risk. I and my family shall not be responsible in any manner for the same. This notice is being issued to protect my interests. Date: 03.08.2026 Place: Delhi

Signature : Nirmal Sikka

Record low Danube levels push some countries in Eastern Europe to brink of energy emergency

Hungary's Paks nuclear plant on brink of shutdown due to the crisis

BUDAPEST: Numerous governments across Central and Eastern Europe are taking steps to conserve electricity and avert an energy crisis as record low water levels on the Danube River have forced power plants to the brink of shutting down.

Persistent drought and successive extreme heat waves have deprived one of Europe's largest rivers of water, pushing the Danube's levels in Hungary's capital Budapest to around 10 centimetres (4 inches) on Monday, well below the previous all-time low of 33 centimetres (13 inches) set in 2018.

Water levels are not expected to rise on the Danube in the coming days or even weeks as no significant rainfall is forecast, and as a renewed extreme heat wave bears down on the region with daytime highs topping 38 Celsius (100 Fahrenheit), electricity and water use are on the rise.



A man walks on the bank of the Danube River as usually submerged areas are exposed amid exceptionally low water levels, in Rasova on Monday

The Danube's record low levels have pushed Hungary's only nuclear power plant, the Soviet-built, four-reactor plant at Paks, to the brink of power-

ing down entirely for the first time in its 44 years in service.

The Paks plant, which uses water from the Danube to cool its reactors, on

Monday was producing only 240 megawatts of power rather than the usual 2,000 due to successive power-downs of its four reactors. AGENCIES

Greek wildfires halted after helicopter crash

ATHENS: Water-dropping planes swooped over a major wildfire west of Athens Monday, a day after a midair collision between two fire-fighting helicopters killed two crew members.

A Greek and a Danish national died and two others - all privately chartered operators - were hospitalised in the collision while the firefighting effort along mountainous and coastal areas at the weekend was hindered by powerful gales.

As parts of southern Europe continued to struggle with high temperatures, firefighters in France guarded against potential flare ups inside a still-burning scar four times the size of Paris.

Strong winds eased Monday, allowing the deployment of 12 water-dropping planes and 11 helicopters around the fire-hit seaside resort of Porto Germenos where multiple evacuations have been ordered.

"To put it in a headline: conditions are better but we are pressing forward because there are still multiple points of activity," Fire Service spokesman Yiannis Artopios said. "This is a difficult fire that has troubled us."

Some 500 firefighters halted the fire's advance but authorities warned areas surrounding Athens remained at high risk. AGENCIES

महाराष्ट्र शासन
सार्वजनिक बांधकाम विभाग
कार्यकारी अभियंता (विद्युत) यांचे कार्यालय
सा.बां. परिसर, जालना रोड छत्रपती संभाजीनगर
E mail :- elauranagabad.ee@gmail.com, elauranagabad.ee@mahapwd.gov.in

दरपत्रके मागविण्याबाबतची सूचना क्र. 05 सन 2026-27

कार्यकारी अभियंता, सा.बां.परिसर, जालना रोड छत्रपती संभाजीनगर हे खालील कामांसाठी / विविध सहित्यांसाठी अंदाजपत्रके / दर अनुवृत्ती तयार करण्यासाठी साहित्य विक्रेते / डिलर्स / उद्योजक तसेच अनुषंगी अभिकरणाकडून स्पर्धात्मक दर मागवित आहे.

सदर दरपत्रके <http://www.mahatender.gov.in> या संकेतस्थळावर दि. 04.08.2026 ते दि. 11.08.2026 रोजी 17.30 वाजेपर्यंत Online पद्धतीने सादर करावे. किंवा कार्यालीन वेळेत कार्यकारी अभियंता, सा. बा. परिसर, जालना रोड छत्रपती संभाजीनगर येथे दरपत्रके सादर करावे. सदर दरपत्रके शक्यतो दि. 14.08.2026 रोजी सकाळी 11.00 वाजता उघडण्यात येतील. सदर बाबींचे तांत्रिक तपशील वरील संकेतस्थळावर व या कार्यालयात उपलब्ध राहतील. अटी व शर्ती असलेले दरपत्रके स्वीकारली जाणार नाही.

CONSTRUCTION OF MARATWADA MUKTI SANGRAM SMARAK AND IMMERSIVE TECHNOLOGY AT TALUKA AND DISTRICT CHH.SAMBHAJINAGAR.

Note: Please visit to <http://www.mahatender.gov.in> notice inviting tender page for detail item description

अटी :-

१ दरपत्रके सोलबंद पाकीटात व कंपनीच्या नाममुदीत पत्रावर सादर करावीत वर नमूद केलेल्या दिनांक व वेळेनंतर दरपत्रके स्वीकारण्यात येणार नाहीत.

२ नमूद केलेले दर हे १० दिवस गाळा राहतील.

३ कोणतीही दरपत्रक कोणतीही कारण न देता नामंजूर करण्याचा अधिकार कार्यकारी अभियंता यांनी राखून ठेवलेला आहे.

४ वरील दर भरताना जी. एस. टी. दर वगळून नमूद करावा अंदाजीत रक्कमेवर नमूद केलेल्या दरानुसार आलेल्या रक्कमेवर १८% नुसार जी.एस.टी. देव राहिल.

जा.क्र.कायाअभि/निविदा/2819 सन-2026-2027

कार्यकारी अभियंता यांचे कार्यालय,
सा. बां. विद्युत विभाग, राज पेद्रोल पंपासमोर,
छत्रपती संभाजीनगर. दि. 30/07/2026

Dgipr/2026-27/2064

कार्यकारी अभियंता
सा. बां. विद्युत विभाग,
छत्रपती संभाजीनगर

AMID CHALLENGING MARKET CONDITION

India’s mfg sector growth falls to five-year low in July: PMI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s manu- facturing sector activity growth fell to a five-year low in July, due to slower rise in new busi- ness orders amid increasingly challenging market condi- tions, a monthly survey said on Monday.

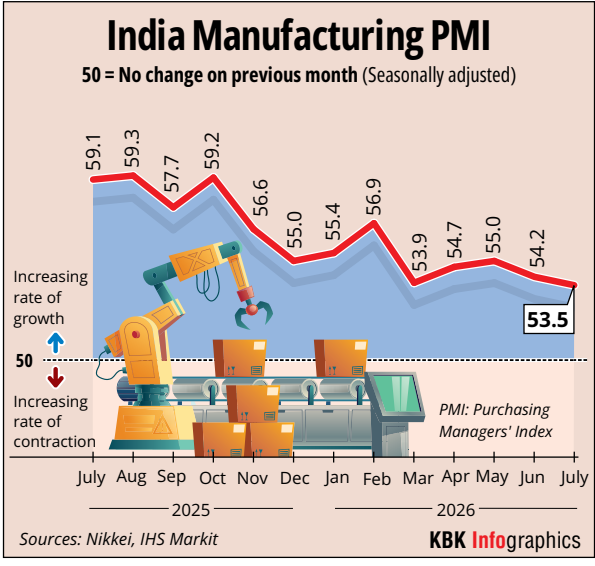
The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing PMI, fell from 54.2 in June to 53.5 in July — the lowest since August 2021 and below the long-run series average of 54.2.

The HSBC India Manu- facturing Purchasing Manag- ers’ Index (PMI) is a gauge of overall conditions derived from measures of new orders, output, employment, supplier delivery times and stocks of purchases.

In the Purchasing Manag- ers’ Index (PMI) parlance, a print above 50 means expan- sion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction. During July, the rate of growth in new orders was the second-weakest in over four years.

Panel members indicated that advertising and demand resilience supported sales, which were somewhat curbed by increasingly challenging market conditions and reduced client interest for key items.

On the employment front, the survey said Job creation across India’s manufacturing



On the employment front, the survey said Job creation across India’s manufacturing industry weakened for the third straight month in July

industry weakened for the third straight month in July. The rate of increase in employment was the slowest in the current 29-month period of uninterrupted growth.

According to the survey, companies saw a notable improvement in supply-chain conditions during July. In fact, input lead times shortened at a

near survey-record pace.

“The suppliers’ delivery times index rose in July, an encouraging sign that supply chain delays are continuing to unwind. However, renewed tensions in the Middle East have raised fresh doubts about how durable these improvements will be,” said Pranful Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The rate of increase in employment was the slowest in the current 29-month period of uninterrupted growth
- » During July, the rate of growth in new orders was the second-weakest in over four years
- » According to the survey, firms saw a notable improvement in supply-chain conditions during July. In fact, input lead times shortened at near survey-record pace
- » ‘Meanwhile, output and new export orders strengthened, pointing to resilient demand, particularly from overseas markets’

new export orders strength- ened, pointing to resilient demand, particularly from over- seas markets. Price pressures also shifted: input cost inflation moderated, but output charge inflation accelerated, indicat- ing firms are once again pass- ing through price increases to protect margins,” Bhandari said.

Meanwhile, cost pressures receded to their weakest in five months, though compa- nies continued to report higher prices for transportation in par- ticular. Meanwhile, there was a moderate increase in selling prices that was broadly simi- lar to June.

“A welcome development was seen for new export orders, which increased at a faster rate. Also, there was a mild recovery in business optimism,” the sur- vey said. There was a marked and accelerated upturn in external orders. Among many, firms noted gains from Can- ada, Egypt, Indonesia, Kenya, Nepal, South Africa, Thailand and the UAE.

Business sentiment strengthened from June’s recent low, with firms sig- nalling a positive outlook for demand, infrastructure proj- ects and new client enquiries. Some businesses expected mar- ket conditions to improve and hoped their marketing initia- tives would pay off.

Sensex rises 544.39 pts, Nifty up 1.60% on sharp drop in oil prices

In four trading days, Sensex jumped 1,873.11 points, or 2.44% and Nifty rose 788.95 points, or 3.28%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Stock market benchmark indices ended higher on Monday, with the Sensex climbing 544.39 points and Nifty surging 1.60 per cent, following a sharp decline in crude oil prices amid easing geopolitical tensions.

Foreign fund inflows also added to markets’ optimism. Extending the winning momentum to the fourth day, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 544.39 points, or 0.70 per cent, to settle at 78,639.03. During the day, it surged 800.46 points, or 1 per cent, to 78,895.10.

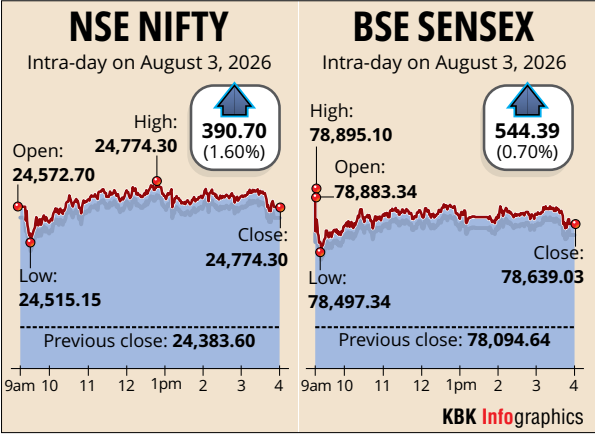
The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 390.70 points, or 1.60 per cent, to end at 24,774.30.

From the Sensex pack, Inter- Globe Aviation, Tata Consul- tancy Services, Infosys, Eternal, ITC, and Axis Bank were among the major winners.

Sun Pharma, Bharti Air- tel, Maruti, and Tata Steel were among the laggards.

The BSE SmallCap Select index climbed 0.87 per cent and MidCap Select index edged higher by 0.73 per cent.

Among sectors, IT jumped 2.53 per cent, Focused IT (2.49 per cent), services (1.97 per cent), industrials (1.23 per cent), commodities (1.20 per cent), metal (1.14 per cent), FMCG (1.13 per cent), insur- ance (1.01 per cent) and PSU bank (1 per cent).



A total of 2,837 stocks advanced, 1,552 declined and 206 remained unchanged on BSE

Hospitals, oil & gas, and healthcare were the laggards. A total of 2,837 stocks advanced, while 1,552 declined and 206 remained unchanged on the BSE.

In four trading days, the BSE benchmark jumped 1,873.11 points, or 2.44 per cent, and the Nifty climbed 788.95 points, or 3.28 per cent.

Meanwhile, Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tumbled 4.62 per cent to \$83.88 per barrel. FIIs bought equities worth Rs 277.48 crore on Friday,

according to exchange data.

After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, pumping in Rs 20,200 crore, aided by attractive valuations, improving corporate earnings and easing global headwinds.

In Asian markets, South Korea’s KOSPI tanked 5.12 per cent. Japan’s Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai’s SSE Compos- ite index also settled lower, while Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index ended higher. Markets in Europe were trading in the green. US markets ended in positive territory on Friday.

On Friday, the Sensex climbed 166.49 points, or 0.21 per cent, to settle at 78,094.64. The Nifty gained 66.45 points, or 0.27 per cent, to end at 24,383.60.

Rupee rises 12 paise to 95.31 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee strengthened against the US currency for the sixth con- secutive session on Mon- day, closing higher by 12 paise at 95.31 following a sharp drop in global crude oil prices and a softer green- back after US President Donald Trump decided to hold off strikes against Iran.

FII inflows and gains in domestic stock markets provided further support to the local unit, forex trad- ers said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.15 against the green- back and traded in a tight range of 95.11-95.34 dur- ing the day.

It eventually settled at 95.31, up 12 paise from its previous close.

The rupee has rebounded by more than 3 per cent in the six trading sessions to Monday, aided by Foreign Institutional Investor (FII) inflows and easing of tensions in the West Asia region. The unit had closed higher by 7 paise at 95.43 against the US dol- lar on Friday.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.07 per cent lower at 99.84.

The RBI data released on Friday showed that the country’s forex reserves jumped \$6.118 billion to \$682.354 billion during the week ended July 24.

In the previous report- ing week, the overall reserves had increased \$1.08 billion to \$676.237 billion.

India-Uzbekistan should work at doubling trade in next three years, says Piyush Goyal

He identified mining, textiles, pharmaceuticals, healthcare, agriculture, food processing, IT and the digital economy as key areas for collaboration

NEW DELHI: Union Com- merce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Monday called for stronger trade and invest- ment ties between India and Uzbekistan, with a target of doubling bilateral trade over the next three years.

Addressing the India- Uzbekistan Business Forum organised by FICCI in part- nership with the Ministry of Commerce and Industry and Uzbekistan’s Ministry of Invest- ment, Industry and Trade, Goyal said trade must lead efforts to strengthen the rela- tionship between the two coun- tries. He urged businesses to invest in each other’s oppor-



tunities and called for remov- ing trade barriers, improving mutual recognition of standards and streamlining approval, test- ing and certification processes.

Goyal said both govern- ments are working towards a structured and outcome-ori- ented partnership to facilitate

businesses. He urged industry to co-invest, co-manufacture and co-innovate, highlighting sectors such as mining, textiles, pharmaceuticals, healthcare, agriculture, food processing, IT and the digital economy for collaboration.

Uzbekistan’s Minister of

Investment, Industry and Trade Laziz Kudratov said bilateral trade grew 30 per cent last year to \$1.3 billion, and expressed confidence of reaching \$2 bil- lion next year and \$3-5 billion in the coming years.

Kudratov said Uzbeki- stan is working with India on trade facilitation measures to improve market access and reduce administrative barriers. He highlighted opportu- nities for Indian companies in mining, metallurgy, chemicals, energy, digital infrastructure, automobiles and pharmaceu- ticals, adding that FDI in Uzbeki- stan has increased tenfold since 2017.

Essar Group marks 15 yrs at Stanlow, unveils £4.3 bn investment pipeline

NEW DELHI: Essar Group is marking 15 years of ownership of the UK’s Stanlow manu- facturing complex, saying it has invested £1 billion in upgrading the refinery since acquiring the site in 2011 and is now pursuing a £4.3 billion pipeline of projects aimed at transforming it into an energy transition hub.

The group in a statement said investments over the past 15 years have reconfigured Stan- low into a single-train oper- ation, expanded the range of crude grades it can process and upgraded its catalytic cracker, helping retain its role as a strate- gic refining asset. Essar Energy Transition Fuels, a wholly owned Essar Group business that owns and operates Stan-

low, recently completed a £100 million (\$130 million) refin- ery turnaround that increased throughput by about 8 per cent. The firm also commissioned the UK’s first hydrogen-ready refinery furnace following a £70.9 million (\$100 million) investment. Essar cited inde- pendent analysis showing Stan- low supports around 5,000 jobs across direct, indirect & induced employment, with a UK supply chain spend of £426 million.

Looking ahead, the com- pany said it plans to expand its retail network by targeting 800 new locations supplied directly from the refinery, advance a £4.3 billion decarbonisation investment pipeline - of which more than £1 billion is nearing

a final investment decision - and explore the development of commercial data centres at the site powered by onsite hydro- gen-ready generation.

“We are proud to mark 15 years since acquiring Stanlow. It remains a privilege to stew- ard this critical asset, and we remain committed to its future. Our £4.3 billion investment pipeline represents a signifi- cant growth opportunity for the UK, supporting the country’s energy transition, generating massive long-term economic value, and creating thousands of highly skilled jobs built on the site’s proud industrial her- itage,” Prashant Ruia, Chair- man of Essar Energy Transition, said.

Essar, IRH execute \$500 mn crude sourcing, product supply facility

ABU DHABI/LONDON: Essar Group and International Resources Holding (IRH) on June 16, 2026 announced the successful execution of a \$500 million crude sourcing facility and product supply facility between Essar Energy Transition Fuels and IRH Global Trading.

IRH, headquartered in Abu Dhabi, UAE, is a global mine-to-market platform that strategically invests in minerals critical to the energy transition and technological advancement.

IRH Global Trading is a wholly owned subsidiary of IRH, and a key global energy trading and liquidity provider. Essar Group is a global conglomerate

with over five decades of entrepreneurial experience in conceptualising, investing, building, and operating world- class assets across the energy, infrastructure, metals & mining, technology & retail sectors.

Through Essar Energy Transition Fuels, owner and operator of the Stanlow Refinery UK, the Group is investing in low-carbon energy solutions and the decarbonisation of its industrial assets. The facility enables Essar Energy Transition Fuels to diversify the crude sourcing and marketing options for its products, while optimising its working capital arrangement. It also strengthens feedstock security

in an increasingly volatile global energy market, enhancing Essar Energy Transition Fuel’s ability to respond to changing market conditions and capture value across its refining and trading activities.

The transaction represents an important step in Essar Energy Transition Fuel’s strategy to forge and strengthen relationships with leading industry players, like IRH Global Trading. The agreement also underscores IRH’s role in enabling secure and efficient energy flows across international markets, while supporting operational optimisation for downstream refining assets.

DLF Ltd posts net profit of ₹794 cr in Q1 FY27

The company’s consolidated revenue stood at Rs 1,605 crore in Q1 of FY27

NEW DELHI: Realty major DLF Ltd on Monday reported a resilient performance for Q1 FY27, supported by disciplined capital allocation and sustained cash flow generation, despite the deferment of certain planned project launches.

On a consolidated basis, DLF Ltd reported revenue of Rs 1,605 crore in Q1 FY27. Gross margin stood at 51 per cent, while EBITDA came in at Rs 476 crore. Net profit was Rs 794 crore and operating cash flow stood at Rs 1,317 crore.

Company’s rental arm DLF Cyber City Developers Ltd (DCCDL) posted consolidated

CLOSER LOOK

- » DLF Cyber City Developers Ltd (DCCDL) posted consolidated revenue of Rs 1,917 crore for the quarter
- » While the net profit of the company (DCCDL) rose 21 per cent year-on-year to Rs 717 crore
- » DLF’s net cash position improved to Rs 15,200 crore at the end of the quarter

revenue of Rs 1,917 crore for the quarter. EBITDA stood at Rs 1,474 crore, registering a year-on-year growth of 9 per cent, while net profit rose 21 per cent year-on-year to Rs 717 crore.

New sales bookings dur- ing the quarter stood at Rs 657

crore, reflecting the timing impact of deferred launches.

The company said it expects to receive the required approvals for the planned launches soon and remains confident of meet- ing its medium-term growth targets, supported by sustained

customer demand, strong brand positioning and a robust launch pipeline. DLF’s net cash position improved to Rs 15,200 crore at the end of the quarter, driven by continued surplus cash gener- ation. Its rental portfolio, span- ning around 50 million square feet, maintained 95 per cent occupancy level.

The company said three new retail destinations with a gross leasable area of about 1.5 mil- lion square feet — DLF Mid- town Plaza in New Delhi, DLF Summit Plaza in Gurugram & DLF Promenade in Goa, are likely to support growth in its retail business in FY27.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for one transmission project and dedicated two significant transmission projects of POWERGRID, during a ceremony in Andhra Pradesh on August 1, 2026. Also present were S Abdul Nazeer, Governor of Andhra Pradesh; Pusapati Ashok Gajapathi Raju, Governor of Goa; N Chandrababu Naidu, CM of Andhra Pradesh; K Pawan Kalyan, Deputy CM of Andhra Pradesh; Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu, Union Minister of Civil Aviation; Bhupathi Raju Srinivasa Varma, Union Minister of State for Heavy Industries and Steel & Nara Lokesh, Minister for IT, Electronics & Communications, HRD & RTG, Govt of Andhra Pradesh.



NBCC (India) Ltd, has signed a landmark agreement with the Government of the Republic of Seychelles for the construction of the Île Aurere Housing Project, comprising 1008 affordable housing units along with associated infrastructure in Seychelles. The agreement was signed by Joseph Francois, Secretary of State, Lands, Housing and Infrastructure, Government of the Republic of Seychelles, and Pradeep Sharma, Executive Director (Engineering), NBCC (India) Ltd on July 29 in presence of Sebastian Pillay, Vice President of the Republic of Seychelles, and Dr. K P Mahadevaswamy, Chairman & Managing Director, NBCC (India) Ltd.

‘SIDBI’S INDIRECT LENDING HITS ₹5.24L CR AS OF MARCH 31’

‘SIDBI expands MSME funding via direct, digital financing schemes’

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: On Monday, the Centre informed the Parliament that the Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) has increased its funding to the MSMEs, largely in the last 12 years, through direct financing, refinancing, digital financing schemes and cluster development initiatives. In a reply to a starred question in the Lok Sabha, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman stated that the total indirect lending portfolio of SIDBI has reached Rs 5.24 lakh crore as of March 31 this year, which is due to the efforts of the centre to provide better access to credit for small firms. The statement was made in connection with questions raised in the Parliament by the MPs Yogender Chandel and Rajiv Pratap Rudy on credit flow to the MSMEs. According to the Finance Min-

CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘SIDBI has taken a multi-pronged approach towards improving credit flow through banks, NBFCs, SFBs & MFIs’
- » ‘SIDBI has also increased its own lending activity through a network of 167 branches throughout the nation’
- » ‘Another important initiative of SIDBI is co-lending with RRBs, NBFCs to ensure credit to under-served borrowers’

ister, SIDBI has taken a multi-pronged approach towards improving credit flow through banks, NBFCs, small finance banks (SFBs) and microfinance institutions (MFIs). “Financial assistance through refinancing and on-lending is provided to banks, NBFCs, SFBs, and MFIs, which in turn use it for funding MSMEs, thus creating a multiplier effect,” said the minister. SIDBI has also increased its own lending activity through a network of 167 branches throughout the nation. SIDBI has rolled out specific micro-lending products targeting

small businesses and women-owned enterprises. Yet another important initiative of SIDBI is co-lending with regional rural banks (RRBs) and NBFCs to ensure credit access to under-served borrowers. Moreover, SIDBI has enhanced digital lending facilities through various tools like GST Sahay, which provides invoice financing, and the Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS). The government also emphasised the significance of the SIDBI Cluster Development Fund (SCDF) that offers

low-cost financial aid to state governments for infrastructure development in MSME clusters. In connection with the Modernisation of Rural Enterprises (MoRE) scheme, SIDBI has taken steps to promote rural non-farm enterprises using a development model based on clusters that involves providing financial assistance, skill development, and capacity building. The government also clarified that ECLGS 5.0 had been operationalised by the government in May 2026. Eligible enterprises are entitled to receive fresh credit worth 20 per cent of their peak fund-based working capital outstanding during Q4 FY26 under the scheme. The government will cover 100 per cent of the risk associated with default by the borrowing companies to the lending institutions. In case of

scheduled passenger airlines, ECLGS covers 90 per cent of the guarantee and the enterprises can avail themselves of 100 per cent of their peak credit exposure (fund-based and non-fund-based). Meanwhile, the centre is anticipating that this program will be able to provide an additional credit flow of Rs 2.55 lakh crore to MSMEs, large borrowers and airlines. According to the information provided by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs to the Parliament, the National Scheduled Tribes Finance and Development Corporation (NSTFDC) continues to extend concessional funding to Scheduled Tribe beneficiaries through several schemes such as Term Loan Scheme, Adivasi Mahila Sashaktikaran Yojana (AMSY), the Micro Credit Scheme for Self-Help Groups (MCF) and the Adivasi Shiksha Rin Yojana (ASRY).



Finance Min Nirmala Sitharaman

the NPS. As on date, there is no proposal under consideration to make any changes or replace the UPS,” she said. UPS was also available to past retirees who superannuated or retired on or before March 31, 2025 under NPS & had completed 10 years of regular service, as well as to the legally wedded spouse of such eligible deceased retirees. The UPS has been envisaged to address the demand of the employees covered under NPS regarding assured pension after retirement while ensuring fiscally responsible funded and contributory pension scheme. As the scheme has been rolled out with effect from April 1, 2025, the government has not reviewed the implementation and performance of the UPS as on date, she said.

“Based on the representations from employees and associations, the cut-off date to opt for UPS was extended up to November 30, 2025. The government extended the benefit of ‘Retirement gratuity and Death gratuity’ under the provisions of the Central Civil Service (Payment of Gratuity under National Pension System) Rules, 2021, to the Central government employees covered by UPS,” she said. Further, she said, the government employees who opted for UPS under NPS shall also be eligible for option for availing benefits under the CCS (Pension) Rules, 2021, or the CSS (Extraordinary Pension) Rules, 2023, in the event of death of the government servant during service or his discharge on the ground of invalidation or disablement. The government also extended tax benefits to UPS as available to NPS, she said. Additionally, she said, the government allowed the Central government employees, who opted for UPS, one-time one-way switch facility to revert to NPS.

SBI Funds Management profit rises 3% to ₹873 cr in June quarter of FY27

NEW DELHI: SBI Funds Management on Monday reported a 3 per cent year-on-year rise in standalone profit after tax to Rs 873 crore in the quarter ended June 2026. The company had posted a profit after tax of Rs 845 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous financial year. Its total income rose 5 per cent to Rs 1,385 crore in the June quarter from Rs 1,324.8 crore in the year-ago period, SBI Funds Management said in a stock exchange filing. Total expenses increased 8



per cent to Rs 242 crore during the quarter under review from Rs 224 crore a year earlier. The company’s mutual fund quarterly average assets under management (QAAUM) stood at Rs 12.6 lakh crore in the quarter ended June 30, 2026,

registering an 11 per cent year-on-year growth. SBI Funds Management retained its position as the country’s largest mutual fund manager, with a market share of 15.1 per cent during the quarter. The company is a joint venture between SBI and France-based Amundi, one of the world’s leading asset management companies. SBI Funds Management made its stock market debut last month, making this its first quarterly earnings announcement since listing on the bourses. PTI

Govt to sell 6.5% stake in LIC at ₹382/share via OFS

NEW DELHI: The government will sell up to a 6.5 per cent stake in Life Insurance Corporation (LIC) at a floor price of Rs 382/share through a two-day offer for sale (OFS) beginning Tuesday. The issue opens for non-retail investors on Tuesday and for retail investors on Wednesday. If fully subscribed, the sale of over 82.22 crore shares or a 6.5 per cent stake at the given floor price will fetch about Rs 31,000 crore to the disinvestment kitty. “Government offers to disinvest 2.5 per cent equity

with an additional 4 per cent as a green shoe option,” DIPAM Secretary Arunish Chawla said in a post on X. The floor price is at a 10 per cent discount over Monday’s closing price of LIC shares of Rs 424.35 on the BSE. The stake sale will help LIC achieve the minimum public shareholding requirement mandated by market regulator Sebi ahead of schedule. Sebi had given LIC time till May 16, 2027, to achieve a minimum 10 per cent public shareholding. PTI

Govt hikes windfall gains tax on petrol, diesel & jet fuel exports

NEW DELHI: The government has hiked windfall gains tax on exports of petrol, diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) for the fortnight beginning Monday. The rate of special additional excise duty (SAED) on export of diesel will be Rs 25.5 a litre, up from Rs 15.5 a litre. SAED on export of ATF will be Rs 22/litre, as against Rs 14.5/litre earlier. Duty on petrol exports has been raised to

Rs 3.5 per litre, from Rs 2.5 per litre levied on July 16. The finance ministry in a notification said the duty hikes will be effective from August 3. Amid escalating tensions in West Asia, the government imposed an export duty on diesel and ATF on March 27 and revised the rate every fortnight. Beginning May 16, the levy was imposed on petrol exports. The ministry also said that

there is no change in the existing duty rates on petrol and diesel cleared for domestic consumption. The windfall tax was levied to increase domestic availability of the fuel amid the war in West Asia. It was also aimed at preventing exporters from taking undue advantage due to price differences as global crude oil prices had risen since the war began. PTI

Sport

Punching above the rest

Boxing boom, judo show power India to strong Glasgow CWG campaign

GLASGOW: India overcame the absence of several traditional medal-winning sports to surpass expectations at the 2026 Commonwealth Games, signing off fourth with 39 medals on the back of a record-breaking boxing campaign, a historic showing in judo, and another strong performance by its para athletes. With the Games reduced to just 10 sports, leaving out wrestling, shooting, badminton and hockey, India’s chances of a top-five finish looked uncertain before the Games began. However, the 122-member contingent returned with 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze medals, underlining the country’s growing depth beyond its traditional strengths. **Boxing led the way** The Indian pugilists produced their best-ever Commonwealth Games campaign, collecting a record seven gold medals and 10 podium finishes overall. While the women lived up to expectations, the men also delivered consistently to make it India’s most successful sport in Glasgow. The performance, however, must be viewed in context. The absence of several European and Central Asian nations meant the competition was not as deep as at the Olym-

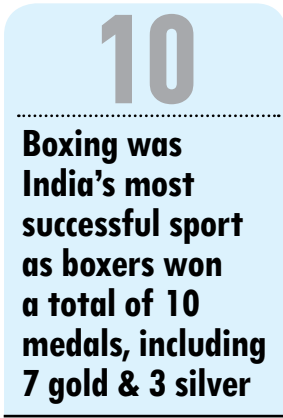


Women boxers pose with their medals

pics or World Championships. Even so, India made full use of the opportunity. **Judo another positive** Long considered a fringe medal sport, it produced India’s best-ever Commonwealth Games performance. Asmita Dey’s gold, won months after losing her father, and Harsh Singh’s title, reflected the steady progress the sport has made over the last few years. **Para sport on the up** From powerlifting to ath-

letics, Indian para athletes once again proved that their success at recent Paralympics was no coincidence. The medals across disciplines reflected the growing strength of the country’s para sports programme. **Athletics a mixed bag** Olympics champion Neeraj Chopra, returning from injury, settled for silver and a few other medal hopefuls failed to meet expectations. At the same time, the sport produced some of India’s most memora-

ble performances. Tejaswin Shankar fought back from a knee injury that ended his high jump campaign to win a decathlon medal, Gulveer Singh emerged as India’s only double medallist with his distance-running exploits, while Murali Sreeshankar marked his return from a lengthy injury lay-off with another Commonwealth silver. Weightlifting, one of India’s most dependable medal-producing sports, had a quieter



Games. After returning with 10 medals, including three golds, in Birmingham four years ago, the lifters managed eight podium finishes but only one gold, won by Mirabai Chanu. But India’s overall performance suggested its medal prospects are no longer tied to just a few established disciplines. The absence of wrestling and other sports could have significantly reduced the medal haul. Instead, boxing delivered in unprecedented fashion, judo emerged as a genuine medal-winning sport and para athletes continued to strengthen India’s position. Equally significant was the contribution from emerging athletes. AGENCIES

NEERAJ’S LAST-SECOND ADVICE HELPED YASHVIR BAG BRONZE

‘Keep spear in one line’: Tip that changed Yashvir’s day

GLASGOW: Yashvir Singh credited a simple piece of last-second advice from Olympics champion Neeraj Chopra for producing the throw of his life, as the Indian javelin thrower surged from seventh place to clinch a bronze medal at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. After the penultimate round, Yashvir was in seventh place with a best throw of 81.33m, while South Africa’s Douw Smit occupied third spot with an effort of 82.88m. “I had to overcome the adverse conditions. Neeraj



Neeraj Chopra takes a selfie with Yashvir Singh

motivated me before my final throw and supported me. He told me to keep the javelin in

one line, and it paid off,” Yashvir told PTI on Monday after receiving a hero’s welcome on

RECEIVES COMMONWEALTH BATON

Cultural spectacle launches India’s CWG 2030 journey

GLASGOW: As the curtain came down on the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, India offered the world a vibrant invitation to Ahmedabad, blending ancient philosophy, contemporary artistry and cultural grandeur in a handover presentation that officially launched the journey towards the centenary edition of the Games in 2030. The emotional centrepiece of Sunday’s closing ceremony at the OVO Hydro saw Glasgow formally pass the Commonwealth Games baton to India before a spectacular showcase of music, dance and storytelling projected India’s identity as a nation where tradition and modernity coexist. Prince Edward, Duke of Edinburgh, representing King Charles III, formally declared the Games closed. “Thanks for the manner in which you have competed, officiated, supported, organised the Games. You have once again brought the spirit and value of Commonwealth tonight. Thank You Glasgow,” he said. “I call up on athletes of all countries and territories to come to Ahmedabad, India in four years time to celebrate the 24th Commonwealth Games in what will be the centenary



Manushi Chhillar performs during the closing ceremony

of the Games,” he added. Jaismine Lamboria carried India’s flag at the closing ceremony after winning gold in the women’s 57kg category boxing competition. The formal handover began with the Commonwealth Games flag making its symbolic journey across the arena. Led by bearers holding the Scottish and Indian flags, the procession lowered the folded Games flag. Glasgow’s Lord Provost Jacqueline McLaren then passed it to Commonwealth Games Scotland vice-chair Susan Jackson, Scottish netball player Emily Nicholl, Commonwealth Sport president Dr Donald Rukare, two-time Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra, Indian Olympic Asso-

ciation president PT Usha, and finally Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Shrivastava. This marked the official transfer of hosting responsibilities from Scotland to India. From that solemn moment, the atmosphere transformed into a celebration of India’s civilisational ethos. The Indian presentation unfolded over three acts, taking the audience on what organisers described as a journey celebrating shared values, culture and connection. The overarching message was rooted in the ancient Indian philosophy of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam -- “The World is One Family” -- a theme that resonated strongly with the Commonwealth’s ideals of unity and friendship. AGENCIES

After Taipei feat, Tanvi eyes Korea crown

ASAN: Newly-crowned Taipei Open champion Tanvi Sharma and a fit-again Kidambi Srikanth will look to continue India’s impressive run on the international circuit when they spearhead the country’s challenge at the Korea Masters Super 300, beginning here on Tuesday. Tanvi, the 17-year-old from Punjab, produced a sensational performance to clinch her maiden BWF World Tour title after defeating Vietnam’s sixth seed Thuy Linh Nguyen in the final of the Taipei Open

on Sunday. The historic triumph made her only the second Indian women’s singles player to win the Taipei Open, joining Saina Nehwal (2008). She also became only the fourth Indian women’s singles shuttler to secure a Super 300 or higher-level title, joining an elite club comprising Saina, PV Sindhu and Devika Sihag. The feat has put her in the spotlight and expectations will be high from the Indian this week as she opens her campaign against a qualifier. AGENCIES

Injured Bumrah out, Auqib gets first call-up

NEW DELHI: Jammu and Kashmir seamer Auqib Nabi on Monday replaced injured Jasprit Bumrah for the upcoming two-match Test tour of Sri Lanka, becoming the first player from the Kashmir valley to get selected in India’s Test squad. Bumrah, originally named in the squad, has been ruled out of the tour as he has not yet fully recovered from the left knee injury sustained during the ODI series against England. It is Nabi’s maiden call-up to the senior national team.

“The Men’s Selection Committee has named Auqib Nabi as Bumrah’s replacement. The Jammu and Kashmir fast bowler earns his maiden call-up to the senior national team,” the BCCI said in a statement. The 29-year-old Nabi, who hails from a remote village in Kashmir’s Baramulla, is the third player from J&K after Parvez Rasool and Umran Malik to get a senior national team call-up. Nabi had claimed 104 wickets across the last two Ranji Trophy, including 60 in the 2025-26 campaign. AGENCIES



'TABAAHI' ROW
HUMA QURESHI
DEFENDS
KIARA ADVANI

Advani is being trolled for her scenes with Yash in the song from the upcoming movie 'Toxic'

Qureshi said the women from the film will have the last laugh once it comes out

Kiara Advani is being trolled for her scenes with Yash in 'Tabaahi', a song from the upcoming movie 'Toxic'. Netizens have been making sexist remarks against the actress, asking why a married woman and mother would do such scenes. But Yash, who is also married and is a father, hasn't received the same kind of hate for the same scenes. Reacting to this, Huma Qureshi said the women from the film will have the last laugh once it comes out, basically saying the movie itself will shut down the critics. Speaking on Yuva's 'Be A Man, Yaar!', the host brought up how Kiara faced far more backlash for her intimate scenes in 'Tabaahi' compared to Yash, even though both actors

are married. Responding to this, Huma said, "It's sick. It's disgusting, absolutely. But I think women in this film, the actresses and the directors, will have the last laugh. There's no point in trying to defend something at all because you can't change people's mindset with words. I would just let the film do the talking. Who are these people? I think the world is a very kind place, but the internet is not." Kiara has been dealing with a wave of criticism and rude comments ever since 'Tabaahi', the debut song from Yash's 'Toxic', dropped online. Trolls extended their attacks to her husband, Sidharth Malhotra, flooding his Instagram with similar remarks. What started out as criticism of Kiara's professional choices soon turned into unwanted commentary on her personal life, her marriage and her bond with Sidharth. AGENCIES

I'm not offered anything here, says Siddharth

The actor said he isn't getting Bollywood offers

Siddharth opened up about his long gap from Hindi cinema and revealed why he has not been seen regularly in Bollywood over the years. The actor, who made his Hindi film debut with 'Rang De Basanti' in 2006, said he has not been receiving the kind of roles that interest him. In a recent interview, Siddharth explained that he can only choose from the projects offered to him and claimed that meaningful opportunities in Bollywood have been lacking.

During an interview with 'News18', Siddharth spoke candidly about the lack of offers

He made it clear that he doesn't view the situation with disappointment

from the Hindi film industry. He said he has not been approached for projects that align with the kind of work he wants to do. "I can only say yes or no to something that's offered to me. I'm not offered anything here. Absolutely nothing! In the kind of work that I would like to do, I'm absolutely not offered anything."

Despite his absence from Bollywood, Siddharth made it clear that he doesn't view the situation with disappointment. Instead, he believes every opportunity arrives at the right time.



Looking back at his career, Siddharth spoke about 'Rang De Basanti', the film that introduced him to Hindi audiences. Two decades later, he is set to portray Squadron Leader Ajay Ahuja in 'Operation Safed Sagar', a role he considers another significant milestone. AGENCIES

FIRST LOOK: JOB TRAFFICKING



OUR CORRESPONDENT

A sneak peek into the world of its new Hindi 'Original' series 'Job Trafficking' was shared by Prime Video. The gripping new survival drama has been created and directed by the renowned director Prashant Nair. The eight-episode series stars Nimrat Kaur, Roshan Mathew, Kavya Trehan and Pavan Malhotra in pivotal roles.

'Job Trafficking' is an

unflinching fictional series that will plunge the viewers into the dark heart of industrialised online scams. Known commonly as 'pig butchering', perpetrators spend weeks, sometimes months, building trust and false intimacy with their victims online before draining them of everything. But what the world rarely sees is the other side: the young people behind the keyboards, lured by fake job offers, trafficked across borders and forced to become the very scam-

mers destroying innocent lives. It's a survival drama that exposes the dark machinery behind one of the world's fastest-growing criminal enterprises.

The series follows three strangers - a trapped scammer fighting to break free, a defrauded housewife seeking answers and a CEO caught in the crossfire - whose paths collide in a dangerous web of fractured trust, deception and exploitation. What begins as a dream of opportunity spirals into a nightmare of captivity and coercion with no way out.

Blending edge-of-your-seat suspense, raw emotion and high-stakes drama, 'Job Trafficking' offers an eye-opening journey into survival, resilience and the fierce will to reclaim one's humanity against impossible odds.



Imtiaz Ali, Anurag Kashyap to present 'Bobby Beauty Parlour'

NEW DELHI: Filmmakers Imtiaz Ali and Anurag Kashyap have turned presenters for the short film 'Bobby Beauty Parlour'.

Directed by Shashwat Dwivedi, the film features Adrija Sinha, Parul Rana, Saksham Raj, Preeti Kochar and others. It will be released on the 'Oh Short Flips' YouTube channel on August 6. The story revolves around childhood friends Eelu and Manu. On their final afternoon together, the pair find themselves trapped inside a neighbourhood beauty parlour - drinking, napping, bickering and desperately holding on to a time that is fast slipping away, as per the official logline.

"The most spectacular moments of life don't scream but remain a part of our character forever. It is such moments that make 'Bobby Beauty Parlour' charming. The film got me remembering my own small hometown, my adolescent decisions and friends that I always carried with me," Ali said.

The film is produced by Janhavi Asthana, Ranjan Singh and Kashyap. PTI

It'll be released on the 'Oh Short Flips' YouTube channel on August 6

A LOVE OTHER THAN YOURS

Love, temptation & complexities of long-term relationships

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video announced 'A Love Other Than Yours', a new Korean romantic series that will premiere exclusively on September 12. Led by acclaimed stars Seo Kang-jun and Ahn Eun-jin alongside co-stars Lee Joo-ahn and Jo Aram, the series explores the fragile line between comfort and passion and whether choosing each other after 10 years is an act of love, habit or survival.

The series follows Namgung Ho (Kang-jun) and Lee Mi-do (Eun-jin), a couple in a 10-year



relationship whose once-burning passion has matured into a quiet trust. He is a sociable man who wins people over within minutes and believes marriage is the natu-



ral next step in their relationship. Mi-do, a film director devoted to her work, finds her heart swayed by another man during a difficult period in her career. As their rela-

tionship begins to falter, they are forced to confront a difficult question: should they move forward with marriage or finally choose a love other than each other's?

Lee Joo Ahn portrays Han Tae-seung, an ambitious attorney at Jaekang Law Firm. An orphan with nothing but his intelligence to rely on, he dedicated his life to serving as the loyal lapdog of Jaekang Law Firm's managing partner. But as he begins questioning his life, he meets Lee Mi-do, a woman who constantly catches him off guard and sparks feelings he refuses to acknowledge.

Jo Aram, former member of K-Pop girl group 'Gugudan', portrays Park Su-a, an employee at Hunmin Snacks. Often called 'cold' and 'prickly', she sees herself as someone who simply isn't naturally warm and expresses her emotions with efficiency. As the daughter of a famous soccer player, she learned to keep her boundaries and show people only what is necessary.

Directed by Hwang Seung-ki ('The Matchmakers', 'Into the Ring', 'Radio Romance') and Lee Garam, the 14-episode KBS series is written by Yoo Su-Ji ('Somehow 18').

'THE BIGGEST RELIGION IS HUMANITY'

Sunny Deol said 'Batwara 1947' captures the human cost of Partition through a mother's story

PATNA: Sunny Deol said his upcoming film 'Batwara 1947' explores the human cost of Partition through the story of a family, with the mother emerging as its emotional core. The Rajkumar Santoshi-directed film is scheduled for release in theatres on August 14. The actor said the film is adapted from acclaimed writer Asghar Wajahat's celebrated play 'Jis Lahore Nai Dekhya, O Jamiy Nai'.

Describing the film as one centred on human relationships, Deol said it underscores the idea that 'a mother is above all religions and faiths'. "The biggest religion is humanity. That is the core of this film," he said, adding that it portrays the impact of Partition on ordinary families.

Asked about the film's central message, Deol said, "The film revolves around a motherly figure. The core message is that a mother is a religion in herself and there is nothing greater than her."

Produced by Aamir Khan Productions, 'Batwara 1947' stars Deol and Preity Zinta as a couple migrating from India to Pakistan during Partition. In Pakistan, they stand up for an elderly woman, played by Shabana Azmi, against a polarised society scarred by the trauma of Partition. The film also features Ali Fazal and Karan Deol, who plays Deol's son on screen. Deol said the film marks the contin-



uation of his long-standing collaboration with director Rajkumar Santoshi, with whom he delivered hits such as 'Ghayal' (1990), 'Damini' (1993) and 'Ghatak' (1996).

"Batwara 1947" is a continuation of my creative partnership with Rajkumar Santoshi ji. The last film I did with him was 'Ghatak' in 1996. Before that, I did 'Ghayal' and 'Damini'. Our earlier films dealt with society and families in different ways. 'Batwara' is also a story of a different kind," he said. Recalling his family's Partition experiences, Deol said he grew up listening to stories narrated by his grandparents. "There was fear in those stories, but they also spoke of people helping one another. Those stories stayed with me," he said. PTI

The film is adapted from acclaimed writer Asghar Wajahat's celebrated play 'Jis Lahore Nai Dekhya, O Jamiy Nai'

